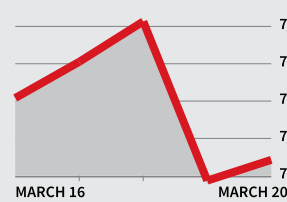


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 74532.96 (-30.96)



IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	23114.50	-36.60
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.46	-0.01
US Dollar (in ₹)	93.71	+1.26
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	146628.00	-11137
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	232364.00	-28124

LOGISTICS.

Old Mangalore Port is set to build a dedicated jetty for ships ferrying daily essentials to Lakshadweep islands **p10**



PULSE.

Indian pharma cautions against IP trade-offs that may hurt the country's health security **p11**

MONDAY SPECIALS.

BRANDLINE

GRT Hotels: Sustainability, spirituality and sleep



Vikram Cotah's stirring human-centric stories on LinkedIn have made the company he leads — GRT Hotels and Resorts — a known name. Cultural storytelling is one of the USPs of GRT Hotels, instilled, no doubt, by its CEO. **p8**

QUANTUM

Defence research stays underfunded

Data from the Ministry of Defence suggest that India's spend on defence research has grown far less than headline numbers indicate. The Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) spent ₹13,258 crore on R&D in 2014-15. By 2024-25, this had risen 87 per cent to ₹24,793 crore, which appears to signal a steady expansion of research effort. But this is in nominal terms. Adjusted for economy-wide inflation, using the GDP deflator, the real annual growth is only 1.5-2 per cent. **p9**

Beyond ESOPs: Executive compensation set for upgrade

TWEAKS IN COMPANIES ACT. Bill proposes to introduce restricted stock units, SARs

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

India's corporate compensation structures are set to move closer to global standards, with the government proposing to allow companies to grant restricted stock units (RSUs) and stock appreciation rights (SARs), alongside employee stock option plans (ESOPs), as executive compensation through amendments to the Companies Act, 2013, and the Limited Liability Partnership (LLP) Act, 2008.

The government has listed the Bill for introduction in Parliament on Monday. Besides expanding stock-linked compensation tools, the legislation proposes enabling hybrid shareholder meetings, easing corporate social responsibility (CSR) compliance for smaller companies and allowing conversion of specified trusts into LLPs.

A key provision seeks to amend Section 42 of the Companies Act, 2013, by inserting the words "or such other scheme linked to the value of the share capital of a company" after the words "employee stock option".

KEY AMENDMENTS

- Simplification of procedures relating to mergers, amalgamations through rationalisation of approval thresholds for fast-track mergers
- Facilitating companies, LLPs in IFSC by allowing them to issue, maintain share capital in foreign currency



This change would formally recognise RSUs and SARs, in addition to ESOPs, as shareholder-approved executive compensation mechanisms.

The move is expected to give companies greater flexibility in designing incentive structures that are used in global markets, particularly in technology, financial services and start-up ecosystems.

Unlike ESOPs, RSUs do not provide employees with an option to purchase shares. Instead, they become entitled to receive shares at the end of a vesting period, subject to meeting tenure and performance conditions. SARs are a deferred compensation mechanism tied to stock performance, entitling employees to receive the monetary equivalent of the

appreciation in the value of a specified number of shares over a defined period, without requiring actual share allotment.

HYBRID AGMs

The Bill also introduces greater flexibility in shareholder engagement by allowing companies to hold annual general meetings (AGMs) either physically or via video conferencing or other audio-visual means, wholly or partly.

Amendments to Section 96 of the Companies Act propose allowing hybrid AGMs while mandating that every company hold at least one physical AGM once every three years. Similarly, amendments to Section 100 propose enabling extraordinary general meetings to be held

Trump, Iran step up threats over energy targets

Reuters

Tel Aviv/Washington

US President Donald Trump and Iran threatened to escalate their war, a potential widening of hostilities that could deepen a regional crisis and add to concerns in global markets.

Trump on Saturday threatened to "obliterate" Iran's power plants if Tehran did not fully reopen the Strait of Hormuz within 48 hours, suggesting a significant escalation barely a day after he talked about "winding down" the war.

Iran said on Sunday it would attack US infrastructure, including energy facilities in the Gulf, if Trump carried out his threat, which he made as US Marines and heavy landing craft continued to head to the region. Parliament Speaker Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf wrote on X that critical infrastructure and energy facilities could be "irreversibly destroyed" should Iranian power plants be attacked.

Meanwhile, the Strait of Hormuz remains open to all shipping except vessels linked to "Iran's enemies", the country's representative to the International Maritime Organisation was quoted as saying in Iranian reports published on Sunday. **Also read p5**

Group of Ministers, Secys to be formed to deal with critical needs of citizens

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday directed the formation of a group of ministers and secretaries to work dedicatedly in a whole of government approach.

"The ongoing conflict in West Asia will have significant short, medium and long-term impact on the global economy, and its effect on India were assessed and counter measures, both immediate and long-term, were discussed," said a statement issued by the government, post the Cabinet Committee of Security meeting chaired by Modi. The meeting was attended by 13 Ministers, including the Home, Defence and Finance Ministers.

The meeting made a detailed assessment of availability for critical needs of the common man, including food, energy and fuel security. Accordingly measures for the short term, medium term and long term were discussed. "The impact on farmers and their requirement for fertilizer for the kharif season was assessed. The measures taken in the last few years to maintain adequate stocks of fertilizers will ensure timely availability and food security. Altern-



Prime Minister Narendra Modi chairing a high-level meeting in New Delhi **p71**

ate sources of fertilizers were also discussed to ensure continued availability in the future," the statement said.

IMPORT SOURCES

The meeting deliberated on diversifying sources of imports required by the chemicals, pharmaceuticals, petrochemicals and other industrial sectors. "Similarly, new export destinations to promote Indian goods will be developed in the near future," the statement said.

During the meeting, Modi instructed that all arms of the government should work together to ensure the least inconvenience to the citizens. "The PM also asked for proper coordination with the State governments to ensure no black-marketing and hoarding of important commodities," the statement added.



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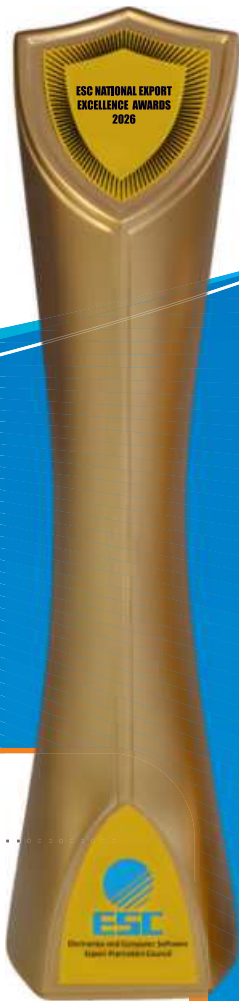


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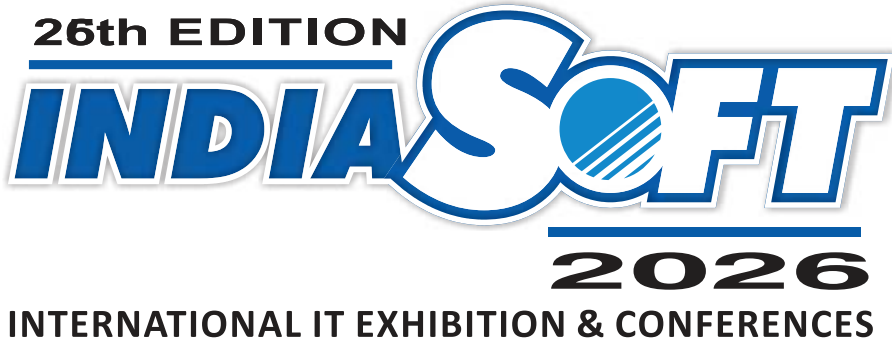
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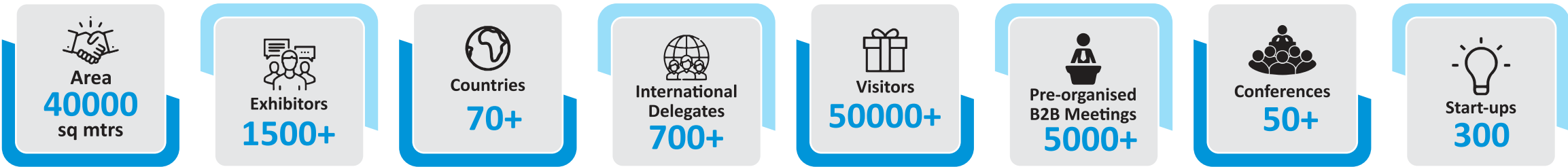
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SHOW HIGHLIGHTS*



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QUICKLY.

Tata Capital gets ₹413-cr tax demand notice

New Delhi: Non-banking finance company Tata Capital has received a reassessment order from the tax authorities, raising a demand of ₹413.18 crore for FY18, the firm said. The order, issued by the Deputy Commissioner of Income Tax, Mumbai, pertains to Tata Capital Financial Services Ltd, which has been merged with Tata Capital with effect from April 1, 2023. The demand arises due to alleged short credit of taxes paid and certain disallowances, the firm said in an exchange filing. ■

Govt to launch auctions for critical minerals today

New Delhi: The government will launch the seventh tranche of auctions for critical and strategic minerals on Monday, putting 19 blocks on sale across several States. So far, the government has conducted six rounds of auctions, with 46 critical and strategic mineral blocks already sold. “Building on this momentum, the seventh tranche will offer 19 blocks across several States under mining lease and composite licence,” the Mines Ministry said. ■

Govt to table CAPF Bill in RS today

THE PROPOSAL. One legal framework for CRPF, BSF, Indo-Tibetan Border Police and Sashastra Seema Bal staff

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Amid a debate around IPS deputation and cadre reforms, Union Home Minister Amit Shah will table the Central Armed Police Forces (General Administration) Bill, 2026, in the Rajya Sabha on Monday.

The proposed law seeks to create a unified legal framework for personnel management across the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs), including the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), the Border Security Force (BSF), the Indo-Tibetan Border Police and Sashastra Seema Bal. At present, each force operates under its own Act, leading to variations in recruitment, promotion and service conditions.

With nearly 10 lakh personnel and tens of thousands of vacancies across ranks, the CAPFs form the backbone of India's internal security architecture.

TO PLUG LOOPHOLES
According to the Bill's objectives, the legislation aims to streamline rules govern-



OPPOSING VOICES. Retired officers, including HR Singh and SK Sood, have expressed concern that the law may adversely impact career progression within the forces ■■

ing recruitment, deputation, promotions and service conditions of Group A general duty officers and other personnel. The government has argued that the absence of a common legal framework had resulted in fragmented regulations and frequent litigation, affecting administrative efficiency.

POWER WITH CENTRE
The Bill seeks to empower the Centre to frame rules, overriding other laws or court orders if necessary, on how officers are recruited, promoted or deputed across

the forces. A key provision in the proposed law formalises the role of Indian Police Service (IPS) officers in CAPFs. It provides that around 50 per cent of Inspector General (IG) posts will be filled through deputation from the IPS. Also, at least 67 per cent of Additional Director General (ADG) posts will be held by deputed IPS officers, while senior-most ranks, including Special Director General and Director General, will be filled entirely through deputation. The move comes in the

backdrop of a Supreme Court ruling in May 2025, which directed the Centre to carry out a long-pending cadre review of CAPFs and gradually reduce IPS deputation in higher ranks. The court reiterated this stance in October 2025 while dismissing the government's review petition.

The judgment also recognised CAPF officers as part of an organised Group A service and flagged concerns over stagnation in promotions due to the lateral entry of IPS officers.

BACKLASH
The proposed legislation has drawn criticism from sections of retired CAPF officers, who argue that it could dilute the Supreme Court's directives.

A group of former senior officers has approached the top court with a contempt petition against Home Secretary Govind Mohan. They also called for the Bill to be referred to a Parliamentary Standing Committee for wider consultation.

At a recent conference, retired officers, including HR Singh and SK Sood, expressed concern that the law

could adversely impact career progression within the forces. They pointed to long-standing issues such as delayed promotions, limited leadership opportunities for cadre officers, and a lack of parity with other services.

Former officers warned that any changes to the command structure or service conditions could have wider implications on morale and operational effectiveness. They argued that personnel serving in high-risk environments require clear career pathways and institutional support.

Some also raised concerns about the continued dominance of deputed officers in senior roles, suggesting that greater representation of internal cadre officers would lead to more grounded decision-making.

The Centre, however, maintains that IPS deputation is essential for preserving the character of the CAPFs as central forces operating in coordination with the States. Officials said the new law is intended to bring clarity, reduce disputes and align administrative practices with evolving operational requirements.

L&T bets on energy transition opportunities amid geopolitical crisis

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Larsen & Toubro (L&T) is stepping up its push into the global electrolyser market, betting on shifting supply chains and rising demand for green hydrogen to create a new growth engine, even as geopolitical tensions change energy strategies worldwide.

The engineering conglomerate is seeing growing interest from international players for its electrolyser solutions, positioning itself as a competitive alternative to European suppliers amid a broader “China+1” sourcing shift, Deputy Managing Director and President Subramanian Sarma said while briefing the media on the impact of the war in West Asia on L&T's operations.

He said L&T was looking beyond the crisis and, in that context, its foray into green energy and alternative fuel sources gain significance. “We are quite seriously working on green hydrogen, electrolysers and green ammonia. We have made some good progress on what we had announced earlier with Itochu,” he said.

SCALING UP
L&T has scaled up its electrolyser technology from 0.5 MW to 4 MW modules, which are currently under testing and will be deployed in its upcoming green hydrogen project at Indian Oil Corporation's Panipat refinery.

The company is also in discussions with global firms for potential exports, with installations likely in regions where renewable power is inexpensive, including West Asia and parts of Asia.

“Global customers are



Subramanian Sarma, Deputy Managing Director and President, Larsen & Toubro

actively evaluating alternative supply sources,” he said, adding that cost competitiveness could help it gain market share against established European manufacturers.

GROUND COVERED
The company has already made progress on its green ammonia plans, including advancing discussions with partners like Japan's Itochu towards a definitive offtake agreement.

In parallel, L&T is expanding its renewable footprint globally, including offshore wind projects in Europe, and solar and wind opportunities in emerging markets.

To diversify geographically, L&T is looking at Indonesia for solar energy, while it is also supplying modules to Australia.

“And one of the biggest breakthroughs we had was in offshore wind in Europe. We have already secured 4 GW of platforms, and we are now very actively engaged with the customer to add an additional 4 GW,” he added.

Independently of the current crisis, the company has been looking to move into Africa and is in discussions with some of the international oil companies, he said.

Skoda Auto Volkswagen India evaluates potential price hikes

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Skoda Auto Volkswagen India (SAVV) is currently monitoring the impact of the West Asia conflict on commodity costs. The premium automaker stated that any potential price hikes for its vehicles will depend on how the situation evolves.

“It would be too early to reflect on the present West Asia crisis. Overall, we have started well, and the industry

is expected to see a higher single-digit growth this year. But, if the crisis and the strife continue, then we will have to really evaluate. The impact of that on the commodity pricing as well as because of the exchange rate will be severe. Time will come when you will have to pass on part of that to the market,” Piyush Arora, MD and CEO of SAVV, told *businessline*.

MARKET MINDFULNESS
Arora noted that manufacturers must remain mindful

of market sensitivity following the GST 2.0 reforms, particularly as the industry gained significant momentum after the initial GST rationalisation.

“Price points came down a little bit, but if the price points go up because of inflationary pressures, we will have to see how the market is reacting to those pressures. Prices went down for different products. Prices with the exchange rate inflation will have a severe impact on a certain category of cars, and on



Piyush Arora, MD and CEO, Skoda Auto Volkswagen India

how much the duty comes down. But I think it is market-driven and finally every-

one will have to take call,” he said.

He emphasised that since Skoda and Volkswagen maintain a high degree of localisation, any decision regarding price hikes will depend heavily on supply chain stability and logistical costs. “With market growth, we will have to take the right decision over what kind of price position we will pass on so that the volume growth expectations are not hindered.”

Audi, the German luxury brand under the SAVV um-

brella, has already announced a price increase of up to 2 per cent, effective April 1, across its entire model range, citing rising input costs and currency fluctuations.

Other German luxury subsidiaries, including Mercedes-Benz India and BMW Group India (including the Mini brand), have announced 2 per cent price hikes, starting April 1, to offset escalating material and logistical hurdles and the depreciating rupee.

Kotak Mahindra Capital to shed 31% stake in Infina Fin

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Kotak Mahindra Bank's wholly-owned subsidiary (WOS) Kotak Mahindra Capital Company (KMCC) will divest 30.99 per cent shareholding in Infina Finance Private Ltd (Infina) for an aggregate consideration of about ₹1,294 crore.

KMCC has entered into definitive agreements for selling a part of its shareholding in Infina, per the private sector bank's regulatory filing.

The Bank's WOS, which is a full-service investment bank, currently holds 49.99 per cent stake in Infina.

SHARE DISPERSION
Infina, founded in 1996, is a non-banking financial company (NBFC) offering products like loan against securities, ESOP financing, loan against property and commercial real estate financing.

The NBFC is classified as an Associate Company of the Bank. As per the aforementioned definite agreements, KMCC will transfer 2,17,899 equity shares, or 9.9 per cent of the share capital of Infina, to Derive Trading and Resorts Private Ltd and Bright Star Investments Private Ltd for an aggregate consideration of ₹413.35 crore.

Further, KMCC will transfer 2,66,321 equity shares, or 12.1 per cent of the share capital of Infina, to the estate of Rakesh Jhunjhunwala, through its trusts, for ₹505.20 crore, and transfer 1,97,870 equity shares, or 8.99 per cent of the share capital of Infina, to KF Trust, an existing shareholder of Infina, for an aggregate consideration of ₹375.35 crore.

The Bank said the aforementioned transactions are subject to the completion of customary conditions and would result in KMCC's stake in Infina reducing to 19 per cent.

Neo Wealth & Asset raises ₹500 cr from TVS Cap

Our Bureau
Chennai

Neo Wealth & Asset Management on Sunday said it has raised ₹500 crore in growth funding from private equity major TVS Capital Fund (TCF) and its affiliates. The funding was raised at a pre-money valuation of ₹10,000 crore.

This is TVS Capital's first investment in the wealth management sector.

The capital will be deployed by Neo Group to accelerate its growth and focus on delivering specialised, knowledge-driven solutions to its clients.

Neo Group claims that it manages approximately ₹1 lakh crore of total client assets, and has ₹50,000 crore of annualised recurring revenue assets under management (ARRAUM).

The investment round makes Neo Group one of the most institutionally capitalised new-age wealth and asset management platforms in India. Its cap table in-



(from left standing) Shajikumar Devakar, Co-founder & CEO, Neo Wealth Management; and Varun Bajpai, Co-founder, Neo Group; (sitting) Nitin Jain, Chairman & MD, Neo Group; Puneet Jain, Co-founder & CIO, Neo Asset Management; and Hemant Daga, Co-founder & CEO

cludes a marquee list of global funds, including Peak XV Partners (formerly Sequoia Capital India & SEA), MUFG Bank and Euclidean Capital.

NEW STANDARD
Neo Wealth Management operates with nearly 150 senior wealth advisors and caters exclusively to UHNIs and family offices.

Its team of fund managers deliver services across alternative asset classes, in-

cluding private credit, infrastructure and private equity.

Shyam Srinivasan, Chairman of the FS Advisory Board at TVS Capital Funds, said, “In Greek, ‘Neo’ means new. In Indian wealth management, it may soon mean the standard. Nitin and his team have built something with genuine depth — in advisor talent, in platform rigour and in leadership clarity.”

Nitin Jain, Chairman & Managing Director, Neo

Group, said, “Our objective has always been to build an enduring institution with strong governance, disciplined capital allocation and client-first alignment. The continued participation of high-quality investors reinforces confidence in our platform.”

Suraj Majee, Principal, TVS Capital, said, “India's wealth management industry is at a structural inflection point. Neo combines the two hardest things to build — trust and talent — into a high-quality, institutional franchise.”

Go Digit, Insurance Dekho, Yubi, Vivriti Capital and Leap Solutions are among a few portfolio companies of TVS Capital.

In June 2025, the PE firm closed its fourth and biggest rupee capital fund till date of ₹3,535 crore on the back of robust participation from institutional investors.

Along with co-investments, the firm looks to make over ₹4,500 crore of investments from this fund, it had then said.

TVS doubles down on agility, localisation and a customer-centric strategy

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru



(from left) Aniruddha Halder, Senior Vice-President, and Gaurav Gupta, President, TVS Motor Company

TVS Motor Company is navigating a volatile global environment with a sharper focus on agility, localisation and customer-centric product development as geopolitical tensions and supply chain disruptions continue to reshape the auto industry.

“It's an evolving situation... Any kind of assessment is a work in progress,” said Gaurav Gupta, President, India Two-Wheeler Business.

“We are assessing it on a real-time basis and are taking actions in the best interest of our customers, employees, and partners,” he added.

The company, which entered the electric two-wheeler market in January

2020, has for the first time crossed 3,00,000 units in annual retail sales.

GOING AHEAD
On the domestic front, it sees strong headroom in electric two-wheelers, where penetration remains in single digits. “What is most important is product-market fit based on deep consumer understanding,” Gupta said.

Its EV portfolio, spanning

premium to mass segments, is evolving alongside shifting consumer expectations.

TVS is also tapping into emerging lifestyle trends, such as adventure touring, which is gaining traction with improved road infrastructure and rising demand for experiential mobility.

“Adventure riding and exploration will grow faster than what we have seen in the past few years,” he said.

Karnataka bypolls: Congress turns to legacy, BJP to cadre

Tejaswini S
Bengaluru

The All India Congress Committee on Sunday officially announced its candidates for the April 9 Karnataka by-elections, fielding Samarth Mallikarjun in Davanagere South and Umesh Meti in Bagalkote.

The seats fell vacant following the deaths of Congress MLAs, making the contests heavily influenced by sympathy and local leadership factors rather than State-wide political trends.

Congress Spokesperson BL Shankar said “these two constituencies have been under Congress control for many years,” especially Davanagere. Analysts said that the Congress' twin strategy, backing political families while signalling outreach to Muslim voters, reflects a compulsion of winnability rather than choice.

Political analyst Harish

Ramaswamy noted, “Congress does not have any alternative. They think sympathy votes will help them win,” pointing to the party's reliance on family candidates after the deaths of MLAs Shamanur Shivashankarappa (Davanagere South) and Hulappa Yamanappa Meti (Bagalkote).

VOTING PATTERNS & BJP
Election analyst Dr Sandeep Shastri emphasised that bypolls are shaped less by larger political narratives and more by local factors.

In Davanagere South, the choice of Mallikarjun reflects the continuing influence of the Shamanur family. Shastri said that although Muslim voters are an important segment, they do not form a majority. He added that they have largely supported the Congress.

“If the Muslims decide not to support the Congress, how the Congress is going to win the seat is a question,” said

political analyst Narayana A.

BJP named Srinivas T Dasakariyappa for Davanagere South and Veerabhadrayya Charantimath for Bagalkote. BJP spokesperson MG Mahesh expressed confidence about victory, claiming largescale anti-incumbency against the Congress. He framed the BJP's nominations as backing a common worker, and added that the party would focus on development and local issues.

Ramaswamy said the BJP

had nominated someone actively working at the grassroots, adding that “in the longer run, it is the BJP which is going to have a stronger route”. He said while Davanagere South may favour the

Congress, Bagalkote could be a winnable seat for the BJP.

Polling is scheduled for April 9, with counting set for May 4.

The writer is an intern

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Missile involved in Bahrain blast was likely fired by the US, finds analysis

WIDESPREAD DAMAGE. Incident highlights the risks of using advanced weapons against cheaper drones

Reuters

An American-operated Patriot air defence battery likely fired the interceptor missile involved in a pre-dawn explosion that injured dozens of civilians and tore through homes in US-ally Bahrain 10 days into the war on Iran, according to an analysis by academic researchers examined by *Reuters*.

DRONE ATTACK

Both Bahrain and Washington have blamed an Iranian drone attack for the March 9 blast, which the Gulf Kingdom said injured 32 people, including children, some seriously. Commenting on the day of the attack, the US Central Command said on X that an Iranian drone struck a residential neighbourhood in Bahrain.

In response to questions from *Reuters*, Bahrain on Saturday acknowledged for the first time that a Patriot missile was involved in the explosion over the Mahazza neighbourhood on Sitra island, offshore from the capital Manama and also home to an oil refinery.



DRAWING FIRE. Debris litters a street in Bahrain, following drone strikes amid the US-Israeli conflict with Iran REUTERS

In a statement, a Bahraini government spokesperson said the missile successfully intercepted an Iranian drone mid-air, saving lives.

“The damage and injuries sustained were not a result of a direct impact to the ground of either the Patriot interceptor or the Iranian drone,” the spokesperson said.

Neither Bahrain nor Washington has provided evidence that an Iranian drone was involved in the Mahazza incident.

The use of costly, advanced weaponry to defend against attacks by far cheaper drones has been a defining feature of the war.

The incident points to the risks and limitations of this strategy. The blast from the powerful Patriot, whether or not it intercepted a drone, contributed to widespread damage and casualties, while Bahrain’s air defences were unable to prevent strikes that night on the nearby oil refinery, which declared

force majeure hours later.

When asked for comment, the Pentagon referred *Reuters* to Central Command, which did not immediately reply to questions.

In response to questions sent to the White House, a senior US official said the US was “crushing” Iran’s ability to shoot or produce drones and missiles.

“We will continue to address these threats to our country and our allies,” the official said, adding that the US military “never targets civilians”. The official did not answer specific questions about the Patriot attack.

On February 28, the first day of US strikes on Iran, an Iranian girls school took a direct hit. Investigators at the US Defence Department believe US forces were likely responsible, *Reuters* first reported, possibly because of outdated targeting data, two US sources previously told the news agency.

Video of the aftermath of the Mahazza blast in Bahrain shows rubble around houses and screaming residents.

CLOSE ALLY OF US

Both Bahrain and the US op-

erate US Patriot air defence batteries in the kingdom, a close US ally located on the Persian Gulf that hosts the US Navy’s Fifth Fleet along with the regional US naval command.

On the night of the explosion in Mahazza, the refinery on Sitra came under Iranian attack, according to Bahraini national oil company Bapco. Videos show smoke rising from the facility on the morning of March 9.

Reuters could not establish whether the cause of the explosion during a night of Iranian attacks on Sitra would have been immediately apparent to the US and Bahraini forces.

Bahrain, in its statement, did not say why it had not mentioned the involvement of a Patriot at the time. Iran’s mission to the United Nations did not immediately respond to a request for comment about the incident.

Produced by Raytheon, part of RTX Corp, the Patriot is the US Army’s primary high-to-medium-range aircraft-and-missile interceptor system and forms the backbone of the US and allied air forces.

Treasury Secy Bessent says US has plenty of funds for Iran war

Reuters
Washington



US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent ruled out pushing for any tax hikes to fund the war REUTERS

The US government has “plenty of money” to fund the war against Iran, but is requesting supplemental funding from Congress to ensure the military is well supplied in the future, US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said on Sunday.

Bessent, speaking on NBC News’ *Meet the Press* programme, also ruled out pushing for any tax increases to fund the war.

The US military’s request for \$200 billion in additional funding for the Iran war faces stiff opposition in Congress, with Democrats and even some Republicans questioning the need after large defence appropriations last year.

Bessent defended the request without confirming the amount. President Donald Trump has not yet sent a request for the Senate and House of Representatives to approve the sum and his administration has made clear that the number could change.

“We have plenty of money to fund this war,” said Bessent.

“This is supplemental. President Trump has built up the military, as he did in

Afghanistan. Administration officials told lawmakers that the first six days of the Iran war had cost more than \$11 billion.

The Republican-led Congress has already approved record funding for the military since Trump began his second term in January 2025. Last month, he signed into law the Fiscal 2026 Defence Appropriations Act with about \$840 billion in funding.

And last summer, over opposition from Democrats, the Republican-led Congress passed a sweeping tax cut and spending bill that included \$156 billion for defence.

DEFENDS TRUMP

Bessent also defended the Trump administration’s moves in recent days to lift sanctions on Iranian and Russian oil.

Doing so, he argued, would allow other countries besides China, including Japan and South Korea, to purchase the oil, while preventing oil prices from spiking to \$150 per barrel and reducing the overall revenues Iran and Russia would receive.

He said a Treasury analysis showed that the maximum extra amount of oil revenue Russia could get would be \$2 billion.

India to focus on core priorities amid WTO reform push at MC14

Amiti Sen
New Delhi



Food security, e-commerce and IFD agreement are on India’s agenda in Yaounde

The WTO is pushing for institutional reforms at the 14th Ministerial Conference, beginning this week in Yaounde, Cameroon, to address an existential crisis caused by its paralysed dispute system, slow-paced negotiations and shifting economic power balance.

But developing nations like India are watchful against the possibility of this further marginalising their core development priorities.

CAUTIOUS APPROACH

India needs to be careful to ensure that the foundational principles of the WTO, of consensus in rule-making, fairness, equity and protection of vulnerable sections, including farmers and the poor, are not diluted, warn experts.

“Developed members like the US and EU are pushing for more flexible rule-making, including expanding plurilateral agreements [that don’t include the entire WTO membership] and re-considering core WTO principles like consensus-based decisions, most favoured nation (MFN) status, and special & differential treatment (S&DT),” according to the World Trade and Development Report, brought out by research body RIS on Saturday.

In contrast, a significant number of developing members have emphasised the systemic importance of pre-

serving these foundational principles, which are critical for the survival of the WTO as a system, emphasising their importance in ensuring fairness, predictability and equitable participation in the global trading system,” it said.

At MC14, ministers’ discussions on reform will include foundational issues regarding the WTO and level-playing field issues, per the WTO.

Focus will also be on restoring the dispute settlement system that has been paralysed by the US, through measures including resolving the impasse over appointments to the Appellate Body.

CONSENSUS NECESSARY

India will need to ensure that the ongoing push for reforms does not sideline its core priorities, including a permanent solution on public stock-holding (PSH) for food security, its opposition to the investment facilitation for development (IFD) agreement, a balanced outcome on

fisheries subsidies, and the long-standing issue of the moratorium on customs duties on e-transmissions.

At MC13 in Abu Dhabi in 2024, India was particularly critical of the IFD agreement, arguing that it was a plurilateral initiative being pushed without consensus and fell outside the WTO’s multilateral mandate.

India maintains that such agreements risk creating parallel rule-making tracks that could erode the principle of inclusivity and weaken the organisation’s consensus-based framework.

WTO GRIDLOCK

India should work to retain the foundational principles of the WTO, including MFN, consensus decision making, and S&DT, said international trade expert Abhijit Das. “It must watch out for attempts to convert WTO into an institution for negotiating plurilateral agreements,” he said.

The WTO gridlock is intensifying as a more empowered Global South refuses to agree to deals that ignore their national interests.

Simultaneously, developed members like the US and the EU are stalling progress on long-standing mandates critical to developing nations. The Trump administration’s use of reciprocal tariffs by passing the WTO’s MFN principle (where all members need to be treated the same) fundamentally challenges the WTO.

MF equity cash holdings up by ₹4,000 crore in Feb

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

AT A GLANCE

- Mutual fund houses have increased the cash holding of equity schemes to ₹2.10 lakh crore in February from ₹2.06 lakh crore in January
- SIP inflows in the last 11 months of FY26 were up 10% at ₹3,17,502 crore against ₹2,89,352 crore in FY25
- The gross redemption from equity schemes has reduced to ₹36,098 crore in February from ₹41,639 crore in January

Mutual fund houses have increased the cash holding of equity schemes by ₹4,000 crore to ₹2.10 lakh crore in February against ₹2.06 lakh crore logged in January due to the market volatility, according to a JM Financial report.

However, steady systematic investment plan (SIP) inflows and the recent fall in markets opening up fresh buying avenues have kept the cash holdings under check.

EQUITY NFOs

Part of the cash build-up could also be due to eight equity schemes raising ₹3,955 crore through NFOs last month. In January, four

equity NFOs mopped up ₹806 crore. The inflows through SIP in the last 11 months of this fiscal were up 10 per cent at ₹3,17,502 crore against ₹2,89,352 crore logged in the whole of FY25.

Akshat Garg, Head-Research & Product at Choice Wealth, said that less than 5 per cent cash holding of MFs does not necessarily mean

there is no redemption pressure but it is simply under manageable limits.

“If there was real stress in the system, cash levels would have moved up sharply as fund managers prepared for outflows. That is clearly not happening right now,” he added.

The MF ecosystem is heavily supported by consist-

around 11 per cent from around \$63,000 on February 28, as per CoinMarketCap data, with the crypto becoming attractive at the lower levels compared to \$92,000-levels in the beginning of 2026. Bitcoin (BTC), Ethereum (ETH) and Solana (SOL) are top choices for crypto investors in March 2026.

TRADING VOLUMES

Trading volumes of crypto-exchanges WazirX, CoinDCX, ZebPay and Bitbns dropped by 70 per cent, 55 per cent, 15 per cent and 29 per cent between January and March, as per Crebaco, a credit rating agency for crypto exchanges and blockchains. However,



exchanges like CoinDCX and WazirX confirmed to *businessline* that users were still putting their trust in the blue-chip cryptos.

“Tokens like BTC, ETH, XRP [Ripple], SOL... remain the top performers. In fact, Ethereum and XRP are seeing renewed interest. Ripple’s emerging \$50 billion valuation has strengthened mar-

ket sentiment, drawing attention from both retail and institutional participants,” a WazirX spokesperson told *businessline*.

According to Sidharth Sogani Jain, Founder of Crebaco and CEO of Blue Aster Capital, this trust in blue-chips stems from the fact that BTC and ETH have managed to perform better during the Middle East crisis compared to other assets.

“Altcoins don’t have any liquidity left in them. Gold silver, all have gone down — except BTC. From the day the war started, BTC is the only asset that has gone up,” said Jain.

Further, BTC and ETH structure also drives confid-

ence as ETF inflows continue to provide a steady demand base, said Riya Sehgal, Research Analyst, Delta Exchange. Particularly in the case of ETH, Sharat Chandra, Founder, EmpowerEdge Ventures, said prices will show upward trends due to tokenisation tail winds.

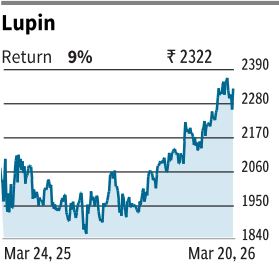
Macro developments will be the decisive driver, as per Vikram Subburaj, CEO, Giotius. Stating that the signal has turned incrementally restrictive, Subburaj said the forward guidance had still shifted toward a ‘higher-for-longer’ stance, with markets now pricing little to no rate cuts in 2026. This is a sharp reversal from earlier expectations, he said.

However, the March numbers will be crucial as the Sensex has already fallen 7 per cent so far this month to 74,533 on Friday from 80,239 on March 2.

TODAY'S PICK.

Lupin (₹2,322.45): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau



The stock of Lupin has been in a steady uptrend since November last year.

It established a fresh rally back then with the help of support at ₹1,900.

The uptrend is still valid despite the recent correction in price. From the current level of ₹2,322, there could be a moderation in price, possibly to ₹2,270.

But eventually, we expect the

stock to begin a fresh leg of uptrend, which could take the price to ₹2,500.

Therefore, participants can buy the stock of Lupin now at ₹2,322 and accumulate if the price dips to ₹2,270. Place stop-loss at ₹2,200.

When the stock rises to ₹2,420, revise the stop-loss to ₹2,350. Tighten the stop-loss further to ₹2,400 when the price touches ₹2,475. Book profits at ₹2,500.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Govt looking at OFS option for IDBI Bank

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The government may consider selling a stake in IDBI Bank through the offer-for-sale (OFS) route to increase public shareholding after the unsuccessful attempt to divest stake in the LIC-controlled lender, sources said.

At present, the public float in IDBI Bank is only 5.29 per cent, limiting the scope of fair valuation. The remaining shares are with the Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC), with a controlling stake at 49.24 per cent, while the government’s holding stood at 45.48 per cent.

Earlier, the proposed sale of a 60.72 per cent majority stake, held jointly by the government and the LIC, was scrapped after bids from two potential buyers reportedly fell short of the reserve price.

thehindubusinessline.
Classifieds

BUSINESS OFFER

GENERAL

LAND INVESTMENT OPPORTUNITIES - CHENNAI
NR ORAGADAM SIPCOT Industrial / Warehouse Land
Near OPR Road
S.P. Koil, Behind Mahindra World City
Layout / Farm Plot Lands
Asset-Backed Security | Customized Options
Land Investment from ₹1.5 Cr onwards
95000 80999
COSMIC PROPERTIES

RENTAL

COMMERCIAL

ALWARPET NR Kaveri Hospital 2 Firs (1500/1700 Sqft.) | Furnished Office Space Cosmic Properties 95000 72727
GUINDY NR Le Meridian Hotel 2500 Sqft Warm Shell Avbl Cosmic Properties 95000 72727

RENTAL

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For Geojit Financial Services Limited
Sd/-
Compliance Officer

Betting big on India

The author explains factors that favour India’s rise

BOOK REVIEW.

Sudhirendar Sharma

The India growth story is fascinating. During the middle of the Mughal regime in 1700s, India accounted for 24 per cent of global GDP. In the next 190 years of brutal British colonialism, it had become an impoverished economy accounting for just 3 per cent of global GDP. For half a century after gaining Independence in 1947, India had too small an economy worth taking note of. However, after several years of steady GDP growth since, it overtook Britain and is on track to overtake Japan and Germany as the world’s third-largest economy by 2030.

Using empirical data and research evidence, Minhaz Merchant argues that there won’t be any European country among the world’s three largest economies. The US believes that as India is on economic ascent, it will be the third economy alongside China to drive global growth. Much will, however, depend on how towards the middle of this century, India upgrades itself with digital technologies and artificial intelligence to lead the world. It is expected that by year 2030, an estimated 70 per cent of Fortune 500 companies will have their capability centres located in India. Its technological infrastructure and expanding consumer market will provide a perfect ecosystem for these companies, and through them for India, to grow.

It isn’t as linear as it may seem. The ongoing trade and technology war between the US and China is recasting global alliances. In such a situation, will India act as a balancing pivot between the two-warring factions? At this crucial time when the US is pushing ‘America First’ policy for seeking revival of its hegemony and China is rising as both an economic and military power, not much can be expected from a third party. The geopolitics of global change is turbulent, with the US playing a vital part in its strategic calculations.

Era of India provides an immensely readable perspective on the social, religious, political and economic history of the world. It traces the rise and fall of civilizations from antiquity to the present. History has been complicated as the weapons of war allowed for invasion and colonisation. Much has changed since then; the stockpile of



Title: Era of India
Author: Minhaz Merchant
Publisher: Penguin Vintage
Price: ₹999

weapons are used instead to influence and enforce change. The book goes a step further to assess the shift in power, triggered by the decline of the West and the rise of the rest. It is an engaging assessment of shifting global power.

GLOBAL POWER TRIAD
History will come full circle, argues Merchant, and applies growth data to prove that three countries — the US, China and India — will exert centripetal force in world affairs in 2050. However, despite economic and military superiority, the three may not be without their own weaknesses and vulnerability. Counting India in this global power triad will favour the US. With India being a major consumer of a variety of products, the US will explore the markets by enforcing favourable tariff regime to dump its products. Incidentally, India may not have any choice.

As the title suggests, *Era of India* narrates all that favours the rise of India. But the questions worth asking are: Where does India stand in this emerging world order? How can China’s role in reshaping the world be ascertained? The homogeneity of Chinese society should be an advantage in taking decisions, whereas the noisy, multicultural societies in the US and India may act as deterrents. Understanding China is critical, strategically. It has not only lifted more people out of poverty faster, but is also the only economic power that has moved closer to the size of the US economy. How India leverages its soft power will determine its status amongst the triad. Merchant leaves it for the reader to take a call.

The reviewer is a writer, researcher and academic

Lupin: The company that DBG built

Desh Bandhu Gupta’s life story and entrepreneurial journey apart, the book outlines early stories of other pharma titans, too

BOOK REVIEW.

PT Jyothi Datta

‘Main zindagi ka saath nibhaata chala gaya, har fikr ko dhuein mein udaata chala gaya’, was a song that “DBG” sang often, reveals the biography of Lupin founder Desh Bandhu Gupta — *Made in India*.

The opening lines of the song from the 1961 film *Hum Dono* featuring Hindi cinema’s evergreen hero Dev Anand, speaks of going along with life and letting worries go up in smoke. But if the biography is anything to go by, DBG comes through as a person who did not merely go with the flow of life — he took hard bets and meticulously planned ahead.

His journey from the dusty tracks of Rajasthan to sky-scraper lined Mumbai (then Bombay) is filled with challenges — from a delayed and expensive medical treatment back home in his childhood that left him with a limp, to business decisions that had the company in a virtual chokehold. But the son of a teacher, from a family of teachers, emerged to build a pharmaceutical company that along with peers scripted a healthy trajectory for itself, and the domestic industry.

The book runs on dual tracks, outlining DBG’s life story and journey building Lupin, alongside early stories of Cipla, the erstwhile Ranbaxy, Dr Reddy’s Laboratories, Sun Pharmaceuticals, Zydus-Cadila and Wockhardt — co-creators of an industry that supplies the developed and developing world with medicines.

The early days saw DBG take a huge leap from being an associate professor at BITS Pilani to eventually becoming an entrepreneur — buying the fledgling Lupin and its five products. Getting approvals and setting up production were not easy, but DBG stayed the

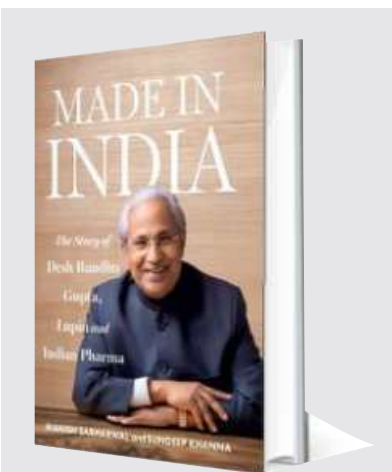
course — not hesitating to move away from a production firm that made its early products, for reasons of quality. When DBG and his wife visited the outsourced production unit making the formulations for Lupin, they found dead mosquitoes in the vats containing the medicine. The area was infamous for mosquitoes, the book notes.

DBG’s wife Manju, coming from an entrepreneurial family, plays a critical role in his business decisions. At the launch of DBG’s biography, she spoke of his support for women, well before it became a point to remember for companies. He sent his eldest daughter Vinita to the US to understand the innovation ecosystem and set-up the business there (1996). Today, Vinita is Lupin’s Chief Executive Officer. His other daughter Kavita played a critical role in India, returning abruptly from Harvard, to help navigate a way through Lupin’s darkest hours in business.

CHALLENGES OF THE TIME
Some incidents the book recounts reveal the challenges of the time — the strike at their Kalina factory, for instance. The narrative paints a dramatic visual image, almost out of a Hindi film of yesteryear — DBG and his brother stood on the equipment when union members threatened to carry it out, it says.

The other narrative that lingers on for a reader is the heart-rending one of the air-crash (Indian Airlines, 1993) in which DBG lost his father and youngest brother Brij — just months head of the company’s IPO. Brij survived the crash, but went back into the wreckage to rescue his father.

Having lost his mother a year ago, and father and brother in a matter of days, the book notes: “Physically, he (DBG) was still strong enough to soldier on, but the mental challenges impacted his day-to-day functioning.” DBG plunged himself into work, the book says. In the parallel narrative on the



Title: Made In India: The Story of Desh Bandhu Gupta, Lupin and Indian Pharma
Authors: Manish Sabharwal and Sundeep Khanna
Publisher: Juggernaut Books
Price: ₹799

MEET THE AUTHOR

Manish Sabharwal is co-founder of TeamLease Services, a leading staffing and human capital firm
Sundeep Khanna has spent three decades as a journalist chronicling Indian business

pharma industry, the book points to two critical policy changes — India’s Patents Act (1970), and America’s Hatch-Waxman Act (1984). The first recognised process patents, allowing companies to make an innovator product through a different process. And the second paved the way for generics with six-month exclusivity for the

first-to-file generic on a new molecule.

In this context, the book famously quotes Cipla doyen Dr Yusuf Hamied’s statement to then Prime Minister Indira Gandhi: ‘Madam, should millions of Indians be denied the use of a life-saving drug just because the inventor doesn’t like the colour of our skin?’ Dr Hamied recollected this, when asked at the panel discussion during DBG’s book launch. Cipla sold cardiac drug propranolol, the first beta blocker in India. This was a generic version of the drug invented by Imperial Chemical Industries (ICI) in England, and globally marketed in 1965. Cipla introduced its version of the drug in India (1972), only to face a patent infringement suit from ICI. The Indian patent landscape has changed in India, since 2005, to honour product patents again.

While DBG steered his ship, he also brought in people to improve governance and growth, for instance. Some decisions worked (Kamal Sharma), while some high-profile appointments did not (Humayun Dhanrajgir), the book reveals. Ramesh Juneja (who founded Mankind Pharma), had a stint with Lupin. So did Sudarshan Jain — Lupin’s first IIM Ahmedabad graduate hire — who later helmed the multinational Abbott in India. He is spokesperson of the Indian Pharmaceutical Alliance — a platform representing large domestic drugmakers.

The narrative of the book could get confusing, especially for a non-industry person, with timelines going back and forth. But the easy narration of incidents that built the industry, keeps it engaging.

Despite all odds, Lupin was among the early companies to outline a clear succession plan, appointing Vinita (based in the US) as CEO, and son Nilesh as Managing Director, in 2013. The sibling-duo have since navigated new business challenges as they build on the vision DBG gave them.

NEW READS.

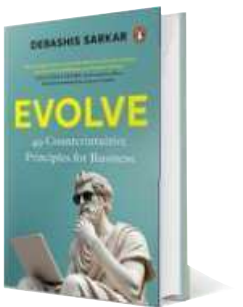


Title: Next In Line: A Youngster’s Guide to Indian Family Business

Author: Avishkar Srivastava

Publisher: Rupa Publications India

The book offers a roadmap to professionalizing operations while strengthening family harmony

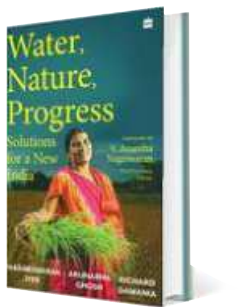


Title: Evolve: 49 Counterintuitive Principles for Business

Author: Debashis Sarkar

Publisher: Penguin Business

The book equips us to see what others miss, giving us a competitive edge through innovation and sharper decision-making



Title: Water, Nature, Progress: Solutions for a New India

Authors: Arunabha Ghosh, Richard Damania, Parameswaran Iyer

Publisher: HarperCollins India

A thorough analysis of India’s water crisis with a call to action on the way forward

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

March 23, 2006

ICICI Bank exits SIB

In a deal valued at over ₹30 crore, ICICI Bank today sold its entire holding of 6.7 per cent stake in South Indian Bank. The deal involving 47.22 lakh shares was executed at an average rate of ₹64.25 per share, according to information published by the stock exchanges. Market sources say that this move could help ICICI Bank present a better balance sheet for the current fiscal. Goldman Sachs Investments and India Capital Fund were the major buyers in the deal.

TRAI bars changing the tariff of lifetime prepaid offer

Lifetime tariff plans offered by cellular operators will indeed be available for a lifetime. The Telecom Regulatory Authority of India has given an order that bars cellular operators from changing the tariff of the lifetime prepaid offer as long as the operator is in business.

Fertilizer units may be forced to trim output

The cash-strapped fertilizer manufacturers may be forced to cut output from the next quarter, if arrears on account of subsidy are not released immediately. This could potentially impact the availability of fertilizers for the ensuing kharif sowing season, it is feared.

Short take

A multi-fuel path to securing cooking energy

Dilip S Patil

As geopolitical tensions in West Asia continue to unsettle global energy markets, India is once again confronted with a structural vulnerability — dependence on imported cooking fuel.

Energy experts and policymakers argue that India must move beyond a single-fuel approach and adopt a diversified, multi-fuel cooking energy strategy one that leverages domestic resources, enhances resilience, and reduces import dependence.

At the forefront of this transition is compressed bio gas (CBG). Produced from agricultural residue, cattle dung, and municipal waste, CBG offers a compelling combination of energy

security and environmental benefits. With an estimated potential of 60-70 million tonnes annually, it can significantly offset natural gas imports while also addressing the persistent issue of farm waste burning.

CBG also supports rural economic development. It generates organic fertilizer as a by-product and creates additional income streams for farmers, effectively transforming waste into value. Under the Sustainable Alternative Towards Affordable Transportation initiative, which targets the establishment of 5,000 CBG plants, the sector is gradually gaining momentum, though scaling remains a challenge.

Ethanol presents another viable pathway, particularly for agrarian regions. Backed by India’s well-established sugar industry,

ethanol-based cooking solutions can be deployed using existing cooperative networks. While ethanol has a lower energy density compared to LPG, advancements in high-efficiency stoves have made it a practical option without compromising cooking performance.

In urban India, the expansion of Piped Natural Gas (PNG) networks is reshaping cooking energy access. Experts suggest blending domestically produced CBG into city gas networks could strengthen resilience while maximising the use of existing infrastructure.

Another emerging option is Dimethyl Ether (DME), which is being evaluated as a transitional fuel. DME can be blended with LPG up to 20 per cent without requiring any modifications to existing stoves or distribution systems.

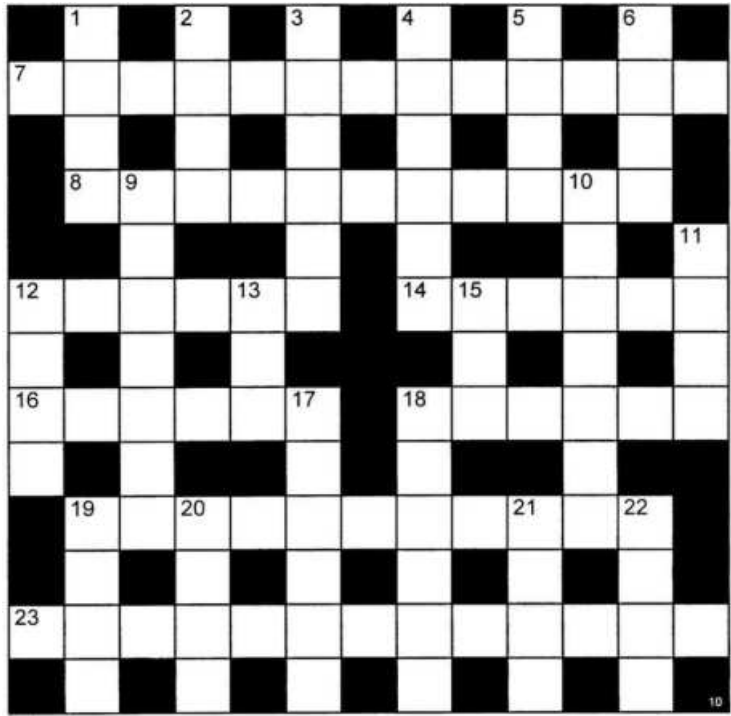
This makes it a practical “drop-in” solution that can reduce LPG imports in the short term without disrupting consumers.

Looking ahead, green hydrogen is being explored as a long-term, transformative solution. Pilot projects, including those demonstrated by IIT Bombay researchers, are showcasing decentralised systems where solar energy is converted into hydrogen for cooking at the village level.

By adopting a diversified fuel strategy and leveraging domestic resources, the country has an opportunity to build a cleaner, more secure, and inclusive energy future — one that reaches every household.

The writer is Managing Director, Samarth SSK Ltd, and Co-Chairperson of the Sugar Bioenergy Forum

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2641



EASY

ACROSS

- Unremitting in effort (13)
- In an everlasting way (11)
- Childishness of old age (6)
- Beginner (6)
- Stepped out (6)
- Upshot (6)
- Holders for cut blooms (6,5)
- Leaves things as they are (4,4,5)

DOWN

- Break (4)
- Look through narrowed eyes (4)
- Injure, harm (6)
- Loft bird (6)
- Huge (4)
- Tenacious earth (4)
- Hold spellbound (7)
- Time free from employment (7)
- Hundredth of dollar (4)
- Quantity of medicine administered (4)
- Object of worship (3)
- Be indebted for (3)
- Cricket team (6)
- Use abusive language (6)
- Dog’s pendulous chop (4)
- Kiln to dry hops, malt (4)
- Underside of foot (4)
- Bird’s melodious outburst (4)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- Can’t be wearied being late if ad is taken out (13)
- In a way meant to last men pay rent - about a pound (11)
- After a party, get a new slant on second childhood (6)
- Depravity is evidently absent in the beginner (6)
- Walked at length on the street - then took a bus perhaps (6)
- The outcome of applying lustre to it (6)
- Floss, we aver, can provide setting for cut blooms (6,5)
- Allows things to stay as they are: doesn’t touch oil supply (4,4,5)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2640

ACROSS 1. Photography 7. Massage 9. Inch 11. Stand 12. Method 14. Centralised 18. Mentor 20. Notch 22. Rare 23. Endures 24. Remorseless

DOWN 2. Hostage 3. Glee 4. Hunch 5. Amuse 6. Shady 8. Audition 10. Designed 13. Bar 15. Extorts 16. Smart 17. Chess 19. Norse 21. Fees

DOWN

- Break : picture it with a biscuit (4)
- Struggle to see a member of the Upper House (4)
- Harm done to a beastly mother with the years (6)
- Homer is one to be readily fleeced (6)
- Huge container with sulphur in it (4)
- Modeller’s material before 4 gets shot at (4)
- Hold one spellbound having perhaps learnt to hold hydrogen (7)
- Relaxation time is lure the East might afford (7)
- A piece of money found in Saracen treasury (4)
- How much is prescribed : it does vary (4)
- An idol is to leave on the 1st December (3)
- There’s nothing you and I have to be indebted to (3)
- Bingo legs make the team (6)
- Assail one bitterly or leer drunkenly when about six (6)
- Not many - about fifty - went by air (4)
- Building for drying nothing that sat around (4)
- The only part of the foot to walk on (4)
- Melody with lyric produced in unison, generally (4)

ON THE CAMPAIGN TRAIL.

Blockbuster release ‘Dhurandhar: The Revenge’ carried the weight of advertising the past fortnight with some 70 brands piggybacking on the movie through campaigns and activations. Beyond that, Ugadi campaigns caught the eye, showing how brands are upping their regional focus

Spykar’s cut

Denim brand Spykar neatly tapped into the buzz around *Dhurandhar: The Revenge*, launching a high-impact co-branded campaign. The raw energy of the movie’s protagonists — be it Ranveer Singh or Sara Arjun — crackles through the campaign, which blends cinematic storytelling with street-led fashion codes. With the tagline ‘Style Ka Asli Dhurandhar’, the campaign champions the unapologetic self-expression, individuality and confidence of young India. Sanjay Vakharia, CEO, Spykar, said, “We’ve always believed in leading from the front. This initiative reflects that — a decisive step to claim space in one of the year’s biggest entertainment moments. This is not just a collaboration, it’s a strategic cultural play.”

Bittersweet celebrations

Parle-G’s Ugadi film for audiences in Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana captures the warmth of the festival while bringing alive a timeless message: Life — like Ugadi’s traditional *bevu bella* (jaggery and neem leaves) — is a blend of sweetness and bitterness. The film unfolds in a typical Kannadiga household preparing for the festival. While the mother decorates the house for Ugadi, the younger daughter sits disconsolately as she has not been selected for her school’s cricket team. Her elder sister playfully points out all her achievements, making her recognise that life has sweet as well as bitter moments.

What’s in a pronunciation?

Flipkart’s Ugadi campaign flagging the festive deals on offer on the site is a light-hearted fun film that taps into the debate around its pronunciation: Ugadi or Yugadi? Conceptualised by 22feet, the campaign is built on the simple insight that while the pronunciation of the harvest festival may differ across States, the spirit of togetherness, festive indulgence and shopping remains the same. The film captures this through a humorous exchange between Telugu and Kannada speakers on the ‘correct’ pronunciation to unlock deals on the Flipkart app.

A matter of faith

In a country where cricket inspires devotion, and prayers are part of everyday life, Zed Black brings the two together. The brand’s new television commercial for its camphor products features MS Dhoni, who appears as a narrator weaving together slices of the life of a student, an office-goer and a shopkeeper, each hoping for a better tomorrow. The film ultimately reinforces the reassuring belief that “Sab Shubh Hoga”.

New journeys

Lufthansa Airlines’ bold out-of-home (OOH) brand campaign, in partnership with WPP Media, offers audiences across multiple locations a tactile preview of the airline’s business class offerings and efficient departure messaging. At Mumbai’s Juhu, striking billboards with a meticulously fabricated 3D replica of Lufthansa Airlines’ new Allegris Business Class seat create an immersive “window to the sky” moment. Meanwhile, dynamic billboards along key airport routes in Delhi, Mumbai and Bengaluru mirror real-time airport departure boards, displaying live flight information. The messaging is that your next journey is just a “yes” away.

● HOSPITALITY HUB

Sustainability, spirituality and sleep

CONSCIOUS STAY. GRT Hotels and Resorts seeks to embed guest experiences with eco-friendly practices and wellbeing initiatives

Chitra Narayanan

Vikram Cotah’s stirring human-centric stories on LinkedIn have made the company he leads — GRT Hotels and Resorts — a known name. Cultural storytelling is one of the USPs of GRT Hotels, instilled, no doubt, by its CEO. Cotah, who comes from a strong cricketing lineage that boasts names like Buchi Babu Naidu (paternal great-grandfather) and Cotah Ramaswami (grandfather), shocked his well-heeled family when he announced he wanted to be a hotelier. “I had gone to visit my uncle at the Taj Coromandel when I was in my teens and immediately decided I wanted to be a hotelier,” he says, describing how, without the support of his family, he graduated in hotel management and became a management trainee at the hotel of his dreams. He did a stint with the Taj group in Maldives, too. The passionate hotelier joined GRT Hotels in the late 1990s when the jewellery retailer GRT Group was setting up its first hotel in Chennai (GRT Grand Chennai in T Nagar). Fast-forward to now and GRT has 22 hotels across southern India and will soon have an international presence in Maldives. Even as GRT was growing its jewellery business (today it has 65-plus stores), the hotels business was expanding in parallel. “The philosophy of our Chairman is that human capital is much more important than



ONCE UPON A... Cultural storytelling is the leitmotif of GRT Hotels properties; (bottom right) CEO Vikram Cotah

profits,” stresses Cotah, adding that it drives the core value of the chain.

EVERY STAY IS A STORY Inspired by Amar Chitra Katha, the group is making every stay into a memorable story. Through comic books titled *The GReaT Katha*, it introduces guests to various experiences at the hotel. The cultural storytelling is evident in other ways too — for instance, at the Radisson Blu GRT hotel near Chennai air-

port, Padma Shri winner Thota Tharani’s gigantic installations transport you to the Chola era even as the hotel chefs deftly serve chocolate rocks inspired by Pallava, Chera, Chola and Pandya dynasties. Besides storytelling, GRT has two other well-thought ‘Ss’ in its strategy — sustainability and spirituality. “The new gen and also the older generation are saying hotels are the worst polluters on earth. So, if we can become sustainable, it’s

going to be a really great step forward for not just hospitality but also regenerative tourism,” says Cotah. He describes how the group’s Tamil Nadu hotels have reduced their carbon footprint through renewable energy — incidentally, supplied by GRT’s renewable power company. The breakfast at the properties are called the Great Sunshine Breakfast. “We offset the entire carbon footprint of this buffet at the Viriksham Foundation.

They plant trees in villages and take care of them. Each tree is about ₹625; the carbon offsets are calculated accordingly,” says Cotah.

PILGRIM’S PROGRESS The hotel chain has also taken a strong positioning in spiritual tourism. “We have covered all the Arupadai Veedu (six sacred abodes) of Lord Murugan,” says Cotah, listing GRT Hotels’ properties on the trail in Tiruttani, Madurai, Salem and Palani. Similarly, it has hotels in strategic locations along the Divya Desam (108 premier Vishnu temples) trail. Finally, the chain is trying to promote good sleep through its ‘GReaT Wellbeing’ initiative. Guests will find magnesium gummies in their room and lavender essential oils. “We do a lot of initiatives on sleep, nutrition, touch therapy and social wellbeing of guests,” says Cotah, describing how, at sundown at the leisure properties, they try to get guests together, and the staff put up a talent show. “These are small things, but make a big difference to guests,” he says.

Given the huge brand-building happening around GRT Hotels — playing on the word GReaT with GReaT Trails, *The GReaT Butterfly Effect* (a book on sustainability) and so on — you can’t resist asking about the need for a partnership with global chain Radisson for some of the hotels. The global distribution muscle is needed is the simple answer.

The writer visited Radisson Blu Hotels & Suites GRT Chennai at the invitation of the global hospitality chain

Another brick in the (fire) wall

Why the recent move to bar children from social media platforms is likely to be ineffective

DIGITAL GADFLY



SHUBHO SENGUPTA

A character in *Adolescence* (the Netflix drama) observes, “You’re never really alone any more. Even when you think you are.” That single line captures the core anxiety driving recent policy moves — from Karnataka to Australia. The question is whether banning access addresses that problem, or merely displaces it. On March 6, Karnataka announced that children under 16 would be barred from social media platforms. Technology companies would be required to implement age-verification systems. Messaging and gaming — where, incidentally, much of the actual harm occurs — would not be covered. Two weeks later, a 14-year-old in Bengaluru opens Instagram. The app asks her age. She types 17. She is in. That is it. And that is the entire problem with Karnataka’s new social media ban — and every ban like it — in one small, effortless gesture. Karnataka is not alone, and it is not even early to the party. Australia enacted what is being called the world’s strictest such law, in December 2025 — a blanket ban on social media access for under-16s, with platform fines of up to \$50 million for non-compliance. France has passed legislation requiring parental consent for children under 15. The UK, Greece, Spain, Norway and Denmark are actively debating similar restrictions. In the US, Utah has moved at the State level. Andhra Pradesh, closer home, has announced a 90-day window to restrict access for children under 13.

The stated reasons are consistent across geographies — the effect on mental health, cyberbullying, screen addiction and declining academic performance. The research supporting these concerns is real, if contested at the margins. The anxiety among parents is genuine and growing. The political will to act — finally, after a decade of hand-wringing — appears to have arrived simultaneously across multiple continents. Which makes this a good moment to ask what exactly are we doing here.

Three parties. Three alibis Governments argue that the state has always drawn lines around what children can access — alcohol, tobacco, adult content, gambling. The logic of extending that protection to algorithmically engineered social media platforms is not, on the face of it, unreasonable. Platforms have had years to self-regulate. They have not. The carousel of apology tours by tech CEOs before various legislatures has produced nothing except improved PR coaching. Someone has to step in. The State is doing it. Platforms counter — not without merit — that age verification at scale is technically fraught and privacy-invasive. Enforcing it meaningfully would require linking social media accounts to government-issued identity documents. In India, that points directly at Aadhaar and, in turn, a different set of concerns: Who holds that linkage, how is it stored, what happens when it is breached, and whether the cure is worse than the disease. They also raise the displacement argument — bans push children towards darker, less regulated corners of the internet. Parents and civil society have



ISTOCK

been watching this exchange for years with mounting frustration. Their position is blunter: “Both of you are deflecting.” Parents have not been asking for improved terms-of-service pages. They want tools. Schools have not been asking for awareness campaigns. They want guidance. The ban — for all its implementation gaps — feels like the first real acknowledgment from authority that something is genuinely, systemically broken. All three positions contain truth. None of them, alone, is sufficient. Wrong question, asked loudly The ban debate, however, keeps skating past a more uncomfortable question. What exactly are we protecting children from? From the platforms? Or from the content that platforms, with great engineering precision, decide to serve? From addiction? Or from the loneliness, the social anxiety, the need for external validation, that makes addiction so appealing in the first place? From their peers? Because peer pressure did not move online. It was always there. It simply found a faster, more public, 24-hour deliv-

ery mechanism. Digital literacy is an alternative most frequently offered by those sceptical of bans. It sounds sensible. Teach children to navigate the internet critically — to recognise manipulation, manage screen time and understand that the algorithm is not their friend. In the abstract, this is obviously the right long-term answer. In practice, ask who teaches it, in which school, in which medium, with what training, funded by whom. In India, the honest answer to that is largely silence. Meanwhile, the platforms are not neutral utilities waiting to be navigated. Their recommendation engines are not passive. They are optimised, at great expense, to maximise engagement — which, for a 13-year-old brain still forming its sense of self, means maximising vulnerability. A ban does not dismantle that architecture. It just puts a gate in front of it. The law exists. Not protection India does not have the infrastructure to enforce what Karnataka has announced. There is no unified digital identity system capable of privacy-preserving age verification at platform scale. Aadhaar linkage is politically contentious and technically risky. A VPN is a five-minute download for any motivated teenager with a smartphone — which is most of them. The enforcement will be uneven in a familiar way. Children from households with attentive, tech-literate parents will route around the ban with guidance or at least awareness. Children from households with less oversight — and arguably more vulnerable to begin with — will encounter it unaided, or not encounter it at all. The promised protection will be distributed by existing privilege.

Australia’s implementation is being watched closely precisely because it is trying to solve this problem rather than simply legislate around it. The results are not conclusive yet. The fines have focused platform attention in a way polite requests never did. Whether the age-verification technology will work at scale, without creating a parallel surveillance infrastructure, remains to be seen.

The algorithm doesn’t wait Every generation produces its moral panic about what children consume. Comics were going to corrupt the young in the 1950s. Television was going to rot their brains in the 1970s. Video games were going to make them violent in the 1990s. In each case, the panic eventually subsided, the medium normalised, and the children turned out — mostly — fine. It is tempting to file social media in that same cabinet, but probably wrong. The previous panics were about passive consumption. This time it’s more insidious — platforms engineered to extract attention, manufacture social comparison, monetise the gap between who a child is and who they fear they are not. The question worth sitting with is not whether governments can ban their way out of this — they probably cannot with the available blunt instruments — but whether the harm being done to adolescent mental health and self-conception, while we debate at legislative pace, is the kind that waits. The 14-year-old in Bengaluru has already logged back in. The algorithm already knows exactly what to show her next.

Shubho Sengupta is a digital marketer with an analogue past and a social provocateur

● B2B BITES

Green, gourmet and regional: Flavours of the AAHAR 2026 exhibition

Chitra Narayanan

Plant-based foods, luxurious chocolate textures, innovative regional offerings and sustainable packaging caught the eye at the just concluded AAHAR 2026 at Delhi’s Bharat Mandapam. A walk through the 40th edition of the food and hospitality fair, which had over 1,800 exhibitors from 17 countries, offered a sneak peek into the flavours and trends set to dominate the year.

PLANT AND PROTEIN PUSH How strongly the culinary compass has swung towards the east was evident in the number of distributors showcasing Korean, Japanese and Thai products. Though Italy as the official

partner country brought a fair share of pasta, olives, and truffles, this time, across halls, one saw a sea of noodles, ramen, rice crackers, kimchi mixes and sauces from Korea and Japan, and exotic fruit from Thailand. Australia had a strong presence with its meats, though, interestingly, it was also pushing plant-based foods, especially a protein-packed flour made of fava beans. BEAN TO BYOND The halls were full of luxurious chocolate innovations, with companies like Morde, 2M Cocoa and Cargill showcasing indulgent products for the bakery sector. But it was Hyderabad-based Beyond’s beautifully designed stall that really stood out. At its centre was a captivating installation of a cacao tree with red and yellow



SNEAK PEEK. Food and hospitality fair AAHAR platformed the flavours and trends set to dominate the year



Kothapally described how he was attempting to raise the profile of Indian-grown cacao and push for pure cocoa-butter products. SEASONING FROM STATES Fascinating regional flavours and enterprise were on view at the fair. At the Kerala pavilion, Subith Kunnamangalam’s Holaa Foods was offering samples of coconut chips and coconut pickles — both of which turned out to be utterly unique and scrumptious. The Kannur-based entrepreneur said he was currently distributing across Kerala but hoped to go national. The Uttar Pradesh pavilion was promoting all its GI-tagged foods — a far-sighted approach by the State in marketing its produce. Pratapgarh *aonla*, Allahabad *sarkha* (guava), Rataul mango,

Mahoba Deshawari *paan*, Kalanamak rice from Gorakhpur, Adamchini *chawal*, Jaunpur *imarti* and Bundelkhand *kathiya gehu* were among the GI-tagged products that were lovingly showcased. IT’S A WRAP Beyond foods, the needle really seemed to have moved in packaging solutions — on display were sustainable and eco-friendly options with a focus on improving shelf-life. Well-known aluminium foil brand Homefoil was advertising all over the fair, promoting its new launch, a grease-proof paper, taking its range beyond its established aluminium, gold and silver foils. It said the grease-proof paper offered oil resistance of up to 168 hours and was biodegradable and non-toxic.

FROM THE LABS.

Micro attacks on sewer lines



Recent studies by scientists at IIT-Madras and the University of Cape Town, South Africa, have demonstrated that corrosion of sewers is driven not by the overall chemistry of wastewater, but the microscopic zones on concrete surfaces where bacteria generate highly concentrated sulphuric acid. While bulk measurements may indicate only mild acidity, the actual corrosion occurs in tiny pockets with extremely low pH.

The scientists — Piyush Chaunsali and Tom Damion of IIT-Madras, and Alice Bakera and Mark Alexander of University of Cape Town — explain why sewer systems, especially concrete ones, corrode more severely than expected. The main culprit is not just chemicals, but also microbial activity. Bacteria in sewage produce hydrogen sulphide gas, which is then converted by other bacteria into sulphuric acid. This acid attacks the concrete, causing major structural damage — accounting for a large share of sewer failures.

A key puzzle addressed in the study is this: real sewer measurements show moderate acidity (around pH 4), yet the kind of damage observed requires extremely strong acid (around pH 1). The researchers resolve this by showing that at the surface, where corrosion actually occurs, the acid is indeed much stronger — but gets quickly neutralised, making it hard to detect.

By combining lab experiments, modelling and field data, the study clarifies how this hidden, highly acidic micro-environment forms — helping anticipate infrastructure damage and in designing improved mitigation strategies.

A key takeaway from the research is that conventional approaches, such as treating the sewage or monitoring average pH, are not good enough. The implication is that solutions must focus on the surface environment: Controlling the bacteria that produce acid, reducing hydrogen sulphide formation and using corrosion-resistant materials or protective coatings.

3D feed for keyhole surgery



Laparoscopic or ‘keyhole’ surgery is increasingly preferred because it reduces pain and speeds up recovery. However, surgeons must operate using 2D video feeds, relying heavily on experience to judge depth. While advanced systems offer 3D visualisation, they are expensive and limited to top hospitals.

Researchers from IIT-Bombay and IIT-Goa have developed a cost-effective alternative — a software technique that reconstructs 3D information from a standard 2D video feed, without requiring specialised sensors or heavy computing. Using principles of geometry, the system tracks surgical instruments by analysing the changes in their shape, size and angles across video frames. As tools move or rotate, their projected appearance shifts in predictable ways, allowing the algorithm to estimate depth and orientation.

The method achieves high accuracy — within about 1 mm — and runs in real time on a standard computer. It promises to make 3D visualisation more accessible and improve surgical training and assistance systems, especially in smaller centres.

MISSING RESOURCES

Defence research stays underfunded

MAJOR DETERRENT. With establishment costs eating into research funding, where does that leave innovation of national importance?

M Ramesh

Data from the Ministry of Defence suggests that India’s spend on defence research has grown far less than headline numbers indicate.

The Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) spent ₹13,258 crore on R&D in 2014-15. By 2024-25, this had risen 87 per cent to ₹24,793 crore, which, at first glance, appears to signal a steady expansion of research effort. But this is in nominal terms. Adjusted for economy-wide inflation, using the GDP deflator, the real annual growth is only 1.5–2 per cent.

The picture becomes starker when looking at how this money is spent. The portion devoted to specific projects and programmes — missile systems, aircraft engines, radars and the like — has moved from ₹3,770 crore in 2014–15 to about ₹5,900 crore in 2025–26. After adjusting for inflation, this implies virtually no growth in real terms over the period.

This also suggests a shift in composition: While overall spending has increased, the share going to R&D projects has not kept pace. A growing proportion of the budget appears to be absorbed by establishment costs rather than programme funding.

Budget trends reinforce this concern. In 2025–26, the allocation for defence R&D was raised by 12 per cent, from ₹23,855 crore to ₹26,817 crore. Yet the revised estimate came in slightly lower, at ₹26,747 crore, indicating that even the allocated funds were not fully utilised.

The increase over the previ-

Funding for the front line				
Year	Budget (2)	Actual (3)	Spent on projects (part of actual) (4)	% of spend on projects in total actual spend (4)/(3) %
2014-15	15,283	13,258	3,770	28.43
2024-25	23,855	24,793	5,432	21.75
2025-26	26,817	*26,747	5,925	22.15

Note: All figures in ₹cr; *revised estimate
Source: MoD reply in Lok Sabha

ous year’s revised estimate was about 8 per cent.

Spending on projects and programmes grew only about 9 per cent in 2024–25.

The pattern raises a broader question: Is higher allocation translating into more research?

The Budget for 2026-27 provides ₹29,100 crore for DRDO, a 10 per cent increase year-on-year. Whether this results in a meaningful increase in programme spending — or is again absorbed by costs — remains to be seen.

A WIDER PATTERN

This scenario is not unique to defence research spending.

Across six key science departments — science and technology, biotechnology, scientific and industrial research, space, atomic energy, and Earth sciences — government R&D spending rose from ₹28,014 crore in 2020–21 to ₹39,057 crore in 2024–25. That translates to a nominal annual growth rate of about 8.8 per cent. Adjusted for inflation, however, the real growth rate is only 2–3 per cent a year.

The pattern is consistent: headline increases mask modest real expansion.

India’s gross expenditure on research and development (GERD) has remained stuck at 0.6–0.7 per cent of the GDP for over a decade. This is not merely because the GDP has grown rapidly, but also because R&D spending has struggled to

grow meaningfully in real terms.

EFFICIENCY FACTOR

It can be argued that limited resources have been used efficiently. India’s rank in the Global Innovation Index has improved significantly over the past decade, and government-backed schemes in areas such as biotechnology have helped startups raise follow-on funding and generate intellectual property.

But these are, at best, partial indicators. Improvements in innovation rankings reflect a broad set of factors, and start-up success in specific sectors is not a fill-in for sustained investment in core research capabilities. The more fundamental question remains unanswered: What might outcomes look like if real R&D spending grew faster?

For a country seeking technological self-reliance, particularly in sectors such as defence, flat real spending and stagnant programme outlays are not neutral outcomes. They imply a slower build-up of capabilities, regardless of improvements in efficiency at the margins. India may indeed be getting more value out of each rupee. But over the past decade, it has not been putting significantly more real resources into research.

We value your feedback.
Do send your comments to quantum@thehindu.co.in

REPURPOSING HARDWARE

Turning the ubiquitous optical fibre into a sensor

K Bharat Kumar

Optical fibre cables have traditionally been used for high-speed telecommunications. But they have another valuable use in industry — as continuous sensors.

Unlike ‘point sensors’, which measure data at specific locations, continuous sensors turn the entire length of fibre into a sensor capable of monitoring conditions across tens of kilometres in real time.

Folium Sensing Co-founder Prof Balaji Srinivasan traces the science’s roots to the 1980s. Fibre was then used to transport data as it minimised data loss and offered high bandwidth. “Whatever is bad for communications — like scattering of light, which causes attenuation (loss) in the fibre as well as external perturbations — turned out to be good for sensing,” he says.

While external vibrations or temperature changes may affect the efficiency of data transmission, they serve as the very signals needed for monitoring. Any existing telecom fibre can be converted into a distributed sensor — equivalent to numerous thermometers or microphones — simply by connecting an instrument to one of its ends.

The instrument sends laser pulses through the fibre and analyses the returning light — much like an echo. This is ‘backscattering’. Folium uses three types of scattering to detect various problems: Rayleigh scattering detects vibrations and acoustics in instances of intrusion or pipeline leaks; Raman scattering is sensitive to temperature for fire detection and power cable monitoring; and Brillouin scattering measures stress or deformation in structures such as bridges and tunnels.

AI/ML models sift through the data to differentiate harmless background noise from critical events, Srinivasan explains. Using the analogy of spotting a friend’s voice in a crowd, he adds: “Once trained to an acoustic signature, you can pick it up in the presence of other acoustic signatures.”

Folium says the oil and gas industry could benefit the most from the technology — existing fibres can offer round-the-clock monitoring for leaks and illegal excavations. IIT-Madras has built a 100 m buried pipeline test bed, one of the largest in the world, to simu-



late various threats. “I can tell between a leak in a pipe and if somebody is using a jackhammer in the vicinity; whether it’s manual digging or an earthmover,” he says. This supplants the need for workers to patrol 50 km stretches on motorbikes daily.

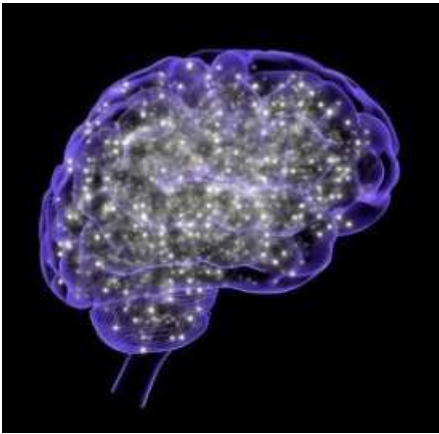
In defence and security, Folium’s technology acts as a quiet ‘sentry’. Srinivasan points out that border areas already have underground fibre cables for surveillance cameras, but intruders can exploit ‘blind’ spots between cameras. Folium’s box can monitor across lengths not possible before. Unlike cameras or electronic sensors that require power sources — a challenge in remote locations — Folium’s sensors rely on light pulses from a central control room, where power is available.

Other important uses include monitoring railway tracks for breaks, detecting train movement and identifying trespassing, including animal crossings, and checking for temperature changes in overhead and underground power cables to prevent degradation of wires or insulation.

In aerospace, Srinivasan has patented a method for monitoring ‘combustion instability’ in jet engines. By tracking the ‘dancing of the flame’ and the acoustics of the combustion chamber, the system can warn pilots before an engine flame-out occurs.

Typically, a single system can monitor up to 100 km, but this can be extended using amplifiers. The world record for such sensing is over 2,200 km. Customers also prefer installing a system every 50 km to maintain the signal and reduce uncertainty.

WOW. Mind-reading tech



Team Quantum

Australian media recently reported on an interesting device that can help paralysed persons “regain connection with the world through text, email, shopping and banking online.”

The matchstick-sized implant, called Stentrode, is placed in a blood vessel near the motor cortex of the brain. Once deployed, it self-expands and stays in position. It senses electrical activity from nearby neurons, particularly signals associated with intended movement. These signals are

transmitted via a thin wire to a small device implanted in the chest, which then sends them wirelessly to an external computer. There, specialised software decodes the patterns and converts them into digital commands — such as moving a cursor, clicking or typing. In effect, the system — developed by a company co-founded by Prof Thomas Oxley of University of Melbourne — translates the brain’s intention, enabling interaction without physical movement.

This development has brought renewed attention to an emerging field known as brain-computer interfaces (BCI). We are familiar with EEG, which reads brain activity through external sensors. Researchers like Oxley are taking the technology much deeper. Most current work on BCI is focused on medicine, including operating wheelchairs and other assistive devices.

Looking ahead, the possibilities are striking — especially when combined with artificial intelligence. One can imagine, for instance, switching off a device at home by thought alone or access data directly from a computer.

Inevitably, there are ethical questions. As Jackson Tyler Boonstra, a postdoctoral researcher at Vrije University Amsterdam, notes in a recent paper, “While BCIs hold transformative potential for treating neurological disorders, their premature translation into consumer markets risks outpacing neuroscientific understanding and ethical frameworks.”

STUDIOUS MACHINES

No exam is too hard for AI?

N Nagaraj

Someone, at some point, perhaps as a joke, decided to call it “Humanity’s last exam”, or HLE. By the time it was published in *Nature* in January, its designers had already announced a replacement. The replacement is updated continuously. It has to be.

It is a benchmark of 2,500 questions assembled by nearly 1,000 experts from 500 institutions across 50 countries, introduced by researchers at the Center for AI Safety and Scale AI. At launch, the best AI models scored under 10 per cent. The live leader board now shows 38.3 per cent. The trajectory, more than the absolute score, is the point.

The benchmark was designed in response to a failure in existing tools for measuring AI capability. Frontier models had already exceeded 90 per cent accuracy on MMLU (massive multitask language understanding), once considered a serious challenge. When all the best systems can clear it, the measuring instrument does not tell you much about the differences between them, or where they may be the following year.

HLE’s design logic was deliberately adversarial. Questions were submitted by experts across more than a hundred disciplines. Before entering the dataset, each had to defeat all current frontier models and pass two rounds of expert review. The result was a set of questions that, by construction, no existing AI could reliably answer.

The evaluation results confirmed the difficulty. At launch, GPT-4o scored 2.7 per cent, Claude 3.5 per cent, Sonnet 4.1 per cent, and OpenAI’s o1 8 per cent. DeepSeek-R1 reached 8.5 per cent. These numbers were low by design. The speed of subsequent progress was not fully anticipated. GPT-5



scored 25.3 per cent, Gemini 2.5 Pro reached 21.6 per cent. Scores have continued to climb; the live leader board now shows Gemini 3 Pro at 38.3 per cent.

Calibration errors across models ranged from 50 per cent to 89 per cent. Calibration measures whether a model’s stated confidence matches its accuracy. On HLE, models routinely expressed high confidence while being wrong. This is not a quirk of one system. It holds across architectures, suggesting a structural feature of current AI design.

Accuracy improved with more reasoning compute, but only to a point. Beyond roughly 16,000 output tokens, performance declined.

DYNAMIC TESTING

The paper reports an expert disagreement rate of 15.4 per cent, rising to 18 per cent in biology, chemistry and health. Nearly one in six questions could not be answered consistently even by specialists. The benchmark is harder than any existing AI can reliably handle, but also harder for any single human expert.

The authors draw one boundary clearly: High performance on HLE would not constitute evidence of artificial general intelligence. It would demonstrate expert-level performance on closed-ended academic questions. That distinction is often lost in public commentary.

There is, however, a deeper problem. Every instrument built to measure AI capability has so far become a ceiling that models eventu-

ally reach. MMLU took years to saturate; HLE is showing pressure within months. The designers acknowledge this by announcing HLE-Rolling, a dynamically updated version intended to stay ahead of the models.

Once a benchmark is published, it becomes a target for developers and for the optimisation logic by which models are compared and sold. The instrument and the thing it measures cease to be independent. No static benchmark can escape this. The inability to build a stable yardstick suggests that capability is moving faster than the ability to define what is being measured.

BUSINESS DECISIONS

For businesses, this has three consequences. Investment and procurement decisions across sectors are being made on capability claims built, directly or indirectly, on benchmark performance. If the benchmarks are structurally unstable, so are those claims.

The calibration finding compounds this. A model that cannot signal its own uncertainty is unsuitable for deployment in contexts where errors compound, including credit assessment, medical triage and document-intensive knowledge work. Confident wrongness is operationally worse than uncertain wrongness because it removes the incentive for a human check.

The pace of improvement also means that any organisation’s current understanding of AI capability has a short shelf-life. Planning and regulatory assumptions require revision cycles that most institutions are not designed to support.

The scores are rising fast enough; so it may not be possible to decide, in any meaningful way, which model is leading. At the margins of a benchmark this hard, differences between the best systems will fall within statistical noise. The yardstick will not so much have been beaten as dissolved.

ATOMIC TEST BED

The PRAGYA tokamak

How and why Bengaluru start-up Pranos Fusion has shrunk a vital component of nuclear fusion reactors

M Ramesh

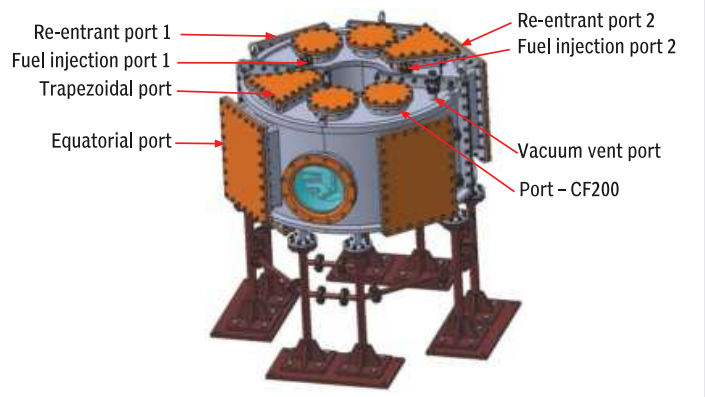
If the headline sounds like the title of a Robert Ludlum novel, the story behind it is just as exciting.

Tokamaks are doughnut-like devices that are the core of nuclear fusion reactors. The ring-shaped vacuum chamber magnetically confines plasma (hot gas of free electrons, which are negatively charged, and positively charged ions). The particles, whose pressure is balanced by the external magnetic field, can only spiral inside the ring, rather than fly off; in the ensuing traffic jam, some collide, fuse and produce energy.

Tokamaks are typically very large — for example, the one used by the International Thermonuclear Experimental Reactor (ITER) in France has a radius of 6.2 m.

Now, a Bengaluru-based startup, Pranos Fusion, has developed a tiny tokamak device with a radius of just 40 cm. It has called it PRAGYA.

3D CAD model of the PRAGYA vacuum vessel assembly



PRAGYA is India’s first privately developed tokamak and also the smallest. The country has three more (under the Institute of Plasma Research, Gandhinagar) — ADITYA-1, ADITYA-U and SST-1, which, incidentally, is special as it

uses superconducting magnets. Pranos Fusion raised \$4,17,000 in May 2025 from Rahul Seth, an angel investor. That money has been put to good use.

PRAGYA is essentially a test bed. It is not a breakthrough in fusion

physics but, nevertheless, a significant milestone because multiple tests (and training) can be done on it, which can lead to a breakthrough.

“This is a small, compact tokamak designed as a precursor to a larger tokamak, with scientific exploration and development of critical human resources as a core objective,” says a paper produced jointly by scientists at Pranos, Jawaharlal Nehru Centre for Advanced Scientific Research (Bengaluru), and the Indian Institute of Science (Bengaluru).

The paper mentions investigations into ‘magnetohydrodynamic stability of plasma’, superconducting magnets and auxiliary heating, among the tests possible on PRAGYA.

Pranos is one of the three private Indian companies working on fusion energy, which is generally considered a big-bucks game. Hyderabad-based Hylemr and Anubal Fusion of Bengaluru are the other two. All three recently raised funds, which indicates investors are willing to bet on fusion energy.

GLOBAL BYTES.

Safe passage for bulk carrier in war zone

A Greek-owned panamax has become the first bulk carrier to transit the Strait of Hormuz with its Automatic Identification System turned on since March 2.



Liberia-flagged, 81,713 dwt *Giacometti* (IMO: 9615377) is owned by Greek bulk carrier company Oceanbulk Shipping. The panamax is the first bulk carrier to transit westbound, or into the West Asian Gulf, since the Panama-flagged *MLS Onyx* (IMO: 9373618) transited on March 5, though that was a so-called “dark transit”, with its AIS turned off.

Maersk’s global gateway in Singapore

AP Moller-Maersk has opened a 1.1 million sq ft, fully automated global and regional distribution centre, the World Gateway II, in Singapore, marking a major expansion of its contract logistics and e-commerce capabilities in the Asia-Pacific region.



Supported by the Singapore government, the facility is designed to serve the rapidly growing demand from companies that rely on Singapore as a regional or global distribution centre due to its prime location and status as a top logistics hub. It also caters to B2B and B2C e-commerce fulfilment across Asia-Pacific. It will handle a wide range of products from verticals including lifestyle, fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG), retail, wellness and technology.

Japan co builds new type of reefer vessel

Cool Carriers, the world’s largest operator of specialised reefer vessels, is set to deploy seven new type of reefer carriers from Kitanihon Shipbuilding in Japan; it took delivery of the first

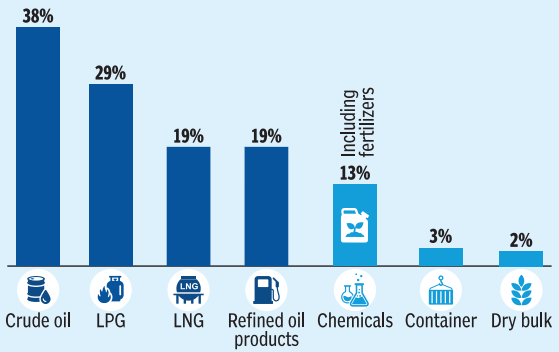


vessel, *Snow Flower*, on March 4. Each vessel is designed to safely carry 5,000 high-cube pallets of perishable fruit, along with up to 168 reefer containers, at a service speed of 18 knots. Two vessels have capacities of over 6,30,000 cubic feet each, while the rest each have capacities of 6,60,000 cubic feet.

All the vessels will share the same specifications and form a new series, with deliveries scheduled from March 2026 to 2028. The names draw inspiration from the company’s original and highly regarded Snow-class vessels.

War clouds over a vital waterway

Share of seaborne trade volume passing through the Strait of Hormuz one week before the US-Israel attacks on Iran began on February 28



Notes: In 2024, total oil transported through the strait was around 20 million barrels per day (bpd), or the equivalent of 25 per cent of global seaborne oil trade. Crude oil and condensate totalled 14 million bpd and petroleum products 6 million bpd. LPG: liquefied petroleum gas, LNG: liquefied natural gas, dry bulk includes grains.
Source: UN Trade and Development, based on data provided by Clarksons Research 2026

RE POSTS.

FACT-owned barge Pearl of Periyar is transporting Liqueified Ammonia Gas from @cochin_port to Ambalamugal via Champakkara Canal (NW-3) in Kerala.
IWAI @IWAL_ShipMin

#ParliamentQuestion: REDUCTION OF CARBON EMISSIONS IN PORT OPERATIONS
The major initiatives include the launch of “Harit Sagar” Green Port Guidelines, implementation of the Green Tug Transition Programme (GTTP) for transition from conventional diesel-powered tugs to electric/hybrid tugs, adoption of renewable energy at ports, electrification of port equipment, vehicles and railway tracks, deployment of zero-emission trucks, and installation of Onshore Power Supply system
Kamarajar Port Limited has also introduced an incentive mechanism to encourage vessels to avail shore power facilities at the port
PIB India @PIB_India

Truck rental rates

Rentals for 18-tonne payload

Truck route	Rentals as on		% change
	Feb 19	Mar 19	
Delhi-Mumbai-Delhi	1,68,000	1,69,000	0.59
Delhi-Nagpur-Delhi	1,58,000	1,57,000	-0.64
Delhi-Kolkata-Delhi	1,67,000	1,69,000	1.18
Delhi-Guwahati-Delhi	1,92,000	1,93,000	0.52
Delhi-Hyderabad-Delhi	1,98,000	1,99,000	0.50
Delhi-Chennai-Delhi	2,14,000	2,16,000	0.93
Delhi-Bengaluru-Delhi	2,20,000	2,20,000	0.00
Delhi-Ranchi-Delhi	1,64,000	1,65,000	0.61
Delhi-Raipur-Delhi	1,62,000	1,63,000	0.61
Delhi-Kandla-Delhi	1,40,000	1,38,000	-1.45
Mumbai-Chennai-Mumbai	1,67,000	1,68,000	0.60
Ludhiana-Hyderabad-Ludhiana	1,98,000	2,00,000	1.00
Mumbai-Kolkata-Mumbai	1,98,000	1,99,000	0.50
Chennai-Ahmedabad-Chennai	2,11,000	2,10,000	-0.48
Bengaluru-Kolkata-Bengaluru	2,09,000	2,16,000	0.48
Bengaluru-Mumbai-Bengaluru	1,37,000	1,40,000	2.14
Delhi-Thiruvananthapuram-Delhi	2,81,000	2,80,000	-0.36
Guwahati-Mumbai-Guwahati	2,81,000	2,80,000	-0.36
Nagpur-Chennai-Nagpur	1,60,000	1,62,000	1.23
Kolkata-Guwahati-Kolkata	1,52,000	1,52,000	0.00
Indore-Delhi-Indore	1,46,000	1,45,000	-0.69
Ahmedabad-Indore-Ahmedabad	96,000	97,000	1.03
Vijayawada-Mumbai-Vijayawada	1,58,000	1,59,000	0.63
Vijayawada-Kolkata-Vijayawada	1,50,000	1,52,000	1.32
Mumbai-Nagpur-Mumbai	1,12,000	1,10,000	-1.82
Mumbai-Pune-Mumbai	60,000	61,000	1.64
Mumbai-Aurangabad-Mumbai	82,000	80,000	-2.50
Mumbai-Nashik-Mumbai	58,000	60,000	3.33

Figures in ₹ Source: Subham Freight Carriers India Pvt Ltd

SUPPLY CENTRAL

A reserved berth for Lakshadweep

VITAL SERVICE. Old Mangalore Port is set to build a dedicated jetty for ships ferrying daily essentials to Lakshadweep islands

AJ Vinayak

In a bid to provide improved cargo and cruise terminal services to ships from Lakshadweep, the Karnataka Maritime Board (KMB) has proposed to develop at Old Mangalore Port a dedicated jetty with allied infrastructure facilities, under the Sagarmala project.

The Lakshadweep islands depend on shipping services from the mainland to meet their day-to-day needs. Given its strategic location, Mangaluru supplies foodgrains and construction material to Lakshadweep.

An attempt to establish a dedicated jetty at Old Mangalore Port was first made a decade ago.

In 2013, during one of his visits to Mangaluru, Lakshadweep Member of Parliament Hamdulla Sayeed had sought the establishment of a dedicated wharf at the Old Mangalore Port to cater to the needs of the islands’ inhabitants. A draft proposal submitted by the Lakshadweep administration that year had sought the construction of a 300-m wharf at the Old Mangalore Port.

A REVIVAL

A decade on, the project is finally moving ahead.

The proposal for the dedicated jetty was approved under the Union government’s Sagarmala project in 2022.

The KMB then awarded the work to a Bengaluru company in 2023. The project proposal estimates the cost of construction at ₹65 crore. This includes a 303.6 m berth for cargo handling, and a 76 m berth for a passenger terminal. It also envisages dredging up to 7 m to accommodate ships.

The dedicated berth aims to facilitate faster berthing and smooth cargo movement, apart from ensuring reliable supply of essential goods to the residents of the Lakshadweep islands. It aims at improving the overall service quality for Lakshadweep vessels.

However, stakeholders in Mangaluru point to the immediate need for dredging at the Old Mangalore Port. This issue



BUILDING LINKAGES. Construction material stacked at Old Mangalore Port for despatch to Lakshadweep islands HS MANJUNATH

came up for discussion at a recent environmental public hearing, chaired by Dakshina Kannada Deputy Commissioner HV Darshan, in Mangaluru. The hearing was held after Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ) clearance was received for the construction of the berth.

FISHERS’ CONCERNS

The Old Mangalore Port is located in the Bunder area of Mangaluru town. Apart from serving a range of needs for the Lakshadweep islands over several decades, the Bunder area has also been a mainstay for the region’s fishing sector.

The Old Mangalore Port is a major fish landing centre. At the public hearing, Abdul Lateef, who represented Bunder in the city corporation council, said the lack of dredging impacted fishing boats. He called for immediate dredging in the Old Mangalore Port area to enable overall development.

Agreeing with this, AK Usman, a Bunder resident, said the number of Lakshadweep-bound vessels calling at the Old Mangalore Port had reduced significantly in recent years as dredging had not been carried out. He sought top priority for dredging at the Old Mangalore Port before commencing work on the dedicated berth project.

GG Mohandas Prabhu, an animal feed wholesaler at Bunder, told *businessline* that his trade with Lakshadweep had plummeted in the last two years due to the drop in ship arrivals.

He has many clients in Lakshadweep, but they currently prefer to source material from Bepore in Kerala, he rued. He hoped that the proposed dedicated berth project, along with the dredging activities, would help put Mangaluru’s trade and commerce with Lakshadweep back on track.

At the public hearing, Chethan Bengre,

a representative of trawl boat owners, wanted to know why the project was delayed despite being approved by the Central government three years ago. Darshan responded that the project would gain momentum soon.

TOURISM POTENTIAL

The KMB expects the dedicated berth at the Old Mangalore Port to save time and money for Lakshadweep vessels through hassle-free cargo movement, and help develop allied and support industries in the region.

The board also foresees the berth giving a fillip to the region’s tourism sector, with the development of luxury water-based attractions.

We value your feedback. Do send your comments to bl.logistics@thehindu.co.in

MOVING PIECES

The overlooked gaps in war-risk cargo coverage



STRAITJACKETED. Marine insurance typically does not cover the cost of rerouting a ship during a conflict REUTERS



BALASUNDARAM R

The impact of the ongoing war in West Asia is being felt across the world. Beyond geopolitics and energy markets, the repercussions are being felt in boardrooms, export houses and logistics companies. Over the past few weeks, there has been a noticeable shift in behaviour among exporters and importers. Insurance policies that were filed away are now being reopened. Clauses that were once assumed standard are now being finely studied.

The question many are asking is simple: Are we really covered if things escalate further? And for many, the answer is not as straightforward as they had thought earlier.

The biggest misconception is around “all-risk” policies.

On the face of it, it sounds like a comprehensive plan that provides protection against all eventualities.

However, an “all-risk” cargo policy does not list everything that is covered. Instead, it lists what is not covered. And among the most important exclusions are war-related risks and strikes-related risks. So, the cover that you need most at times like these may be the one that is specifically excluded.

War, civil unrest, terrorism and strikes are not automatically included in standard marine cargo policies. Typically, cargo insurers provide war and strikes cover by attaching the ‘institute war’ and ‘institute strikes’ clauses to the policy, in case of movement by sea or air. In fact, even terrorism, which many assume falls under war, is typically classified under the ‘strikes’ group of perils. So, unless specifically added to the policy, these risks remain uncovered.

UNDER-INSURED BUSINESS

There are broadly two kinds of gaps in insurance that are now coming to light. First, a lack of awareness. Many businesses genuinely believe their existing cargo insurance protects against any disruption. The second is a conscious decision to avoid additional premium. Even when aware that war and strikes covers are optional, some choose not to include them, especially when operating in regions that are considered “high-risk” but not actively at war.

This approach may work in stable times. But in volatile environments, it can expose businesses to significant financial loss. The reality is that risk builds up gradually.

WAR AND STRIKES COVER

‘Institute war’ and ‘institute strikes’ clauses are additional covers and priced separately, although

in softer markets they may sometimes be bundled into a composite premium. The clauses provide protection against physical loss or damage to cargo arising from war-related events or strikes and associated disturbances.

However, there are specific conditions that are often overlooked. For instance, war-risk coverage begins only once the cargo is loaded onto the vessel or aircraft. Goods awaiting loading at a port or airport are not covered.

Another important limitation is the exclusion of what is known as “frustration of voyage”. If a shipment cannot reach its intended destination due to conflict and has to be rerouted, returned or off-loaded at an intermediate location, the additional costs are typically not covered.

These are not minor details. In a disrupted global supply chain, they can significantly alter the financial outcome of a shipment.

Unlike many other risks, war-related cover is highly dynamic. Insurers continuously reassess exposure based on geopolitical developments. As a result, war and strikes clauses can be modified, re-priced or even withdrawn at short notice. This means that having the cover once is not enough. Businesses need to ensure that the cover remains valid throughout the transit period.

The writer is Head of Marine Insurance at Policybazaar for Business

WINNING IDEA.

Kochi to repeat water metro feat in Mumbai



BOATING AROUND MUMBAI. The waterfront ferry terminal at the Gateway of India ISTOCK

V Sajeew Kumar

In a landmark step towards redefining urban mobility in India, Kochi Metro Rail Limited (KMRL) has submitted a detailed project report (DPR) for developing a modern passenger water transport (PWT) system across the Mumbai Metropolitan Region, in collaboration with the Maharashtra Maritime Board (MMB).

Building on the success of the Kochi Water Metro, the proposed initiative aims to leverage Mumbai’s extensive coastline and waterways to create an integrated, efficient and environmentally sustainable transport network tailored to the region’s unique geography.

The proposed PWT system is envisioned as a low-emission, eco-friendly alternative that will enhance regional connectivity, reduce congestion on existing road and rail corridors, and support economic growth and tourism. The DPR outlines a comprehensive approach for developing both new and existing routes, including the construction of modern terminals and upgradation of existing jetties, officials said.

The proposed network includes 11 new routes supported by 24 terminals, which will be integrated with 25 existing terminals, including six common terminals serving both systems. The total route length would increase to over 215 km from the existing 128 km. The project envisages a fleet of 148 boats for the proposed routes and 49 boats for the existing network, alongside six emergency response vessels. The estimated cost of the project is ₹6,067 crore.

The routes would connect key urban centres and growth corridors across the Mumbai Metropolitan Region, including Vasai and Mira Bhayander, Kalyan-Dombivli and Thane, Airoli, Vashi and the Navi Mumbai International Airport, as well as prominent coastal and business hubs such as the Gateway of India, Bandra, Worli and Nariman Point. These corridors are expected to significantly improve multimodal integration and last-mile connectivity, offering commuters a faster and more comfortable alternative to conventional modes of transport. The project also focuses on the development of new terminals and the modernisation of existing infrastructure, ensuring seamless integration with other modes of public transport. The key terminals at Gateway of India, NMIA and Nariman Point are being aligned with the parallel infrastructure initiatives undertaken by the MMB to maximise efficiency and commuter convenience.

Kochi Metro Rail Limited has also expanded its national footprint by submitting feasibility study reports for implementing water metro systems in 16 other cities across India.

MY FIVE.

ANKUSH GROVER
Co-founder and Global CEO,
Rebel Foods



Small daily habits, no quick fixes

- 1 Journey: I began my health journey in September 2024 with a simple goal — to become fitter, stronger and more disciplined. Over the past year I have lost more than 70 kg through structured nutrition, strength training and consistent routines. The transformation reshaped not just my body but also my mindset, energy levels and mental clarity.
- 2 Consistency: Fitness is now my anchor. I train four to five days a week, largely focused on strength training and progressive overload. Tracking workouts and steadily increasing intensity keeps the process measurable and motivating, even with a demanding professional schedule.
- 3 Mindful: Nutrition has been equally important. I focus on mindful eating, prioritising high-protein meals, balanced portions and maintaining a steady calorie deficit. Being conscious about food choices and consistency has helped me build healthier habits without relying on extreme approaches.
- 4 No quick-fix: I have realised that long-term health is built on small daily habits — sleeping well, training regularly, staying active and maintaining discipline — rather than chasing extreme diets or quick fixes.
- 5 Wind down: My day usually ends with a light dinner and fun time with my two daughters. Those moments help me unwind, stay grounded and recharge for the next day.

CAPSULE.

Child mortality stays high

An estimated 4.9 million children died before their fifth birthday in 2024, including 2.3 million newborns, according to new



estimates, the World Health Organization said. Most of these deaths are preventable with proven, low-cost interventions and access to quality healthcare.

Citing the report, ‘Levels & trends in child mortality’, the WHO said that under-five deaths globally had more than halved since 2000. However, since 2015, the pace of reduction in child mortality had slowed by more than 60 per cent.

For the first time, the report estimates deaths directly caused by severe acute malnutrition (SAM) — more than 1,00,000 children aged 1-59 months in 2024. The toll is far greater when indirect effects are considered, as malnutrition weakens children’s immunity and increases their risk of dying from common childhood diseases.

Newborn deaths account for nearly half of all under-five mortality, reflecting slower progress in preventive care around the time of birth. The leading causes of death among newborns were complications from pre-term birth (36 per cent) and complications during labour and delivery (21 per cent).

COMING UP.

TB endgame: Yes, we can

The theme of World TB Day 2026 — ‘Yes! We can end TB!’ — is a call to action, affirming that it is possible to get back on track and turn the tide on the TB epidemic, even in a challenging global environment, the WHO said. With decisive country leadership, increased investment, rapid uptake of new WHO recommendations and innovations, accelerated action and strong multi-sectoral collaboration, ending TB is not just aspirational, it is also achievable, the WHO added, ahead of World TB Day (March 24).

ON THE WATCH

‘Special 301’ report, in a time of strife

FINE BALANCE. Indian pharma cautions against IP trade-offs that may hurt country’s health security

PT Jyothi Datta

Against the backdrop of trade discussions and the war in West Asia, the United States Trade Representative (USTR) will come out with its annual Special 301 report, a document that assesses its trade partners on their handling of intellectual property rights. The report is scheduled for late April.

The IP report card of sorts could have more of an edge this time, given the geopolitical strife and the bilateral trade discussions underway, caution Indian pharmaceutical industry experts, urging the Centre to ensure that the country’s “health security” is not compromised by potential IP trade-offs.

The Special 301 report has, in the past, put India on the “priority watch list”, and domestic pharma industry associations have called for a recalibration of that status — as the Indian government has made policy changes to address concerns raised by the US administration, echoing concerns outlined by its own industry representatives, they say.

Ahead of its report, the USTR has received over 100 comments/submissions from across the world, including representations from the Indian Pharmaceutical Alliance (IPA), a platform for large domestic drugmakers, and the Pharmaceutical Research and Manufacturers of America (PhRMA).

India’s situation is different from other countries that faced reciprocal tariffs and were negotiating deals involving only that, says Dr Biswajit Dhar, development economist and former professor, Jawaharlal Nehru University. “We have a ... full-fledged BTA (bilateral trade agreement),” he adds. “The tariff thing was only round 1. If you have to get a full-fledged agreement, then... other things come in.” And if the Trump administration does not get market access, it could go for other aspects, especially IP, he cautions.

Pharma industry representat-



ives say (off-record) that the war has added another layer of uncertainty, making trade discussions and potential IP and other concessions that much more critical.

‘DISCRIMINATORY’

In its submission to USTR, PhRMA raises issues such as the inclusion of some patented drugs in India’s National List of Essential Medicines, which are subject to price controls; features in India’s amended Patents Act such as pre-grant oppositions (allowing a patent application to be contested); and Section 3(d), which prevents companies from extending the patent on a drug through incremental changes that do not add to the medicine’s effectiveness.

Pointing to an “unpredictable patent environment”, PhRMA says, “India’s legal and regulatory systems pose longstanding substantive and procedural barriers for innovators, including impermissible hurdles to patentability per Section 3(d) of India’s Patents Act, 1970.”

Further, on the “lack of patent enforcement” and “discriminatory and non-transparent” policies, the submission says, “The overall lack of transpar-

ency, predictability and reasonableness in implementing policies that impact pricing of medicines creates an unviable business environment.”

Dhar points out that the US administration had been raising these issues earlier too, echoing the concerns of its pharmaceutical industry. These issues “will be pushed... onto the negotiating table and then, of course, they will try to get the best deal out of it”, he says.

Citing the example of agriculture in India, he says farmers ensured that the government took a position in the interest of food security. The ability to produce medicines involves the country’s health security, and “there is no reason why we should treat these two things differently”, he says, adding that the cost of medicines is the largest component in a health budget.

BIO-PHARMACEUTICALS

Pointing to the significance of bio-pharmaceutical medicines and Budget 2026’s proposal to boost the manufacture of these drugs, he says the domestic bio-pharmaceutical industry should have the policy space and flexibility to grow.

FROM THE REGULATOR

Alternatives to animal use in drug testing

The US Food and Drug Administration has issued a draft guidance to help drug developers validate new approach methodologies (NAMs) as an alternative to animal testing, and to bring safe, effective drugs sooner to market based on human-centric data.

This marks another major milestone in the implementation of the FDA’s roadmap to ending the use of animal testing as the default method for gaining drug safety information.

Under the FDA’s regulations, drug sponsors must submit non-clinical pharmacology and toxicology data before the investigational drugs can proceed to clinical trials.

While many studies have traditionally depended on animal testing, the Center for Drug Evaluation and Research (CDER) routinely reviews data from NAMs when the methodology demonstrates reliability and scientific validity.

“Technological advances are allowing us to move beyond animal testing in drug development, which has a poor track record of predicting safety and efficacy in humans,” said FDA Commissioner Marty Makary. “This guidance will facilitate the adoption of modern alternatives to animal testing in regulatory submissions.”

Examples of NAMs include innovative testing such as complex and two-dimensional in-vitro (laboratory) studies; three-dimensional models such as organoids, spheroids and organs on chips; chemical reactivity studies; computer simulations or in-silico modelling; and studies using “phylogenetically lower” animals such as zebrafish or *C elegans*. There are now several examples of validated NAMs outperforming unvalidated animal models in predicting human responses to drugs.

NAMs can identify toxicities, demonstrate how the investigational drug works, improve predictivity of non-clinical studies, and enhance the safety of future clinical trials.

While the guidance provides general validation considerations for NAMs used in drug development, it does not address specific methodologies or drug discovery applications. FDA encouraged drug developers to consult with the appropriate FDA review division when considering NAMs, particularly for indication-, disease-, organ- and endpoint-specific applications.



ISTOCK

Source: USFDA

LENS ON HEALTH



BREAKING THE CHAIN. People, mainly students, queue to receive meningitis B vaccinations on the University of Kent campus, following an outbreak of meningitis in Canterbury, Britain REUTERS

India’s silent newborn crisis

BY INVITATION



KISHORE KUMAR

India is confronting a silent, yet entirely preventable postnatal crisis. One in every 1,000 babies born in India has congenital hypothyroidism (CH) which, if left undetected, can lead to permanent intellectual disability.

CH occurs when a baby is born without a thyroid gland or an underdeveloped or poorly functioning one. The thyroid produces thyroxine (T4), a hormone essential for brain development, growth and metabolism. In the earliest weeks of life, thyroxine plays a decisive role in neuronal development and brain maturation. This period represents a narrow but critical window.

If adequate thyroid hormone is not available during this time, the consequences can include irreversible intellectual disability, stunted physical growth, hearing impairment and delayed motor development. The most alarming aspect is that the affected babies almost always appear completely normal at birth. Without screening, there are no obvious clinical signs to alert families or healthcare providers.

Globally, the incidence of CH is one in 2,500-3,000 live births. In India, given the higher prevalence and the estimated 26 million births annually, each year at least 10,000 babies are born with congenital hypothyroidism, as per data with the National Neonatology Forum of India. That roughly means at least 27 babies each day and one baby each hour. Every single one of these infants has the potential to lead a normal, productive life if diagnosed and treated within two weeks of birth, through mandatory early newborn screening.

AFFORDABLE TEST

CH is identified using a simple heel-prick blood test 48–72 hours after birth. The test measures thyroid stimulating hormone (TSH) levels and, when implemented at scale, costs approximately ₹50 per baby. If diagnosed promptly, the treatment involves daily oral levothyroxine, which is inexpensive, safe and widely available. When initiated within the first 14 days of life, the treatment enables children to achieve normal in-



CRITICAL WINDOW. A heel-prick blood test 48-72 hours after birth can detect congenital hypothyroidism ISTOCK

tellectual and physical development. In contrast, untreated CH can reduce IQ by 30-50 points. The difference between a healthy future and lifelong disability rests on testing a drop of blood.

The lifetime care of a child with severe intellectual disability includes special education, repeated medical consultations, rehabilitation therapies and long-term dependency. In a country where out-of-pocket healthcare expenditure remains high, this can push households into financial distress and intergenerational disadvantage.

The next phase of progress must focus on safeguarding neurodevelopment and ensuring quality of life. Most developed nations have implemented universal newborn screening for CH for nearly six decades, virtually eliminating it as a cause of avoidable cognitive impairment. India, despite its expanding healthcare infrastructure, still lacks mandatory nationwide screening.

Universal newborn screening for CH must be integrated into all public and private birthing facilities. This requires policy mandates, structured funding, standardised testing protocols, public awareness initiatives and centralised data monitoring systems to ensure compliance and accountability.

The science is unequivocal. The screening test is simple and affordable. The treatment is effective. What is missing is collective will. Protecting a child’s brain at birth is not optional; it is a national responsibility and a measure of our commitment to future generations.

The writer is President, National Neonatology Forum of Karnataka. Views are personal

Hitting a pothole: ‘Medical miracle’ or misdiagnosis?

Doctors explain that brain death is irreversible, and misdiagnosing erodes trust in critical care

J Mangaiyarkarasi

Recently a woman from Pilibhit (Uttar Pradesh) who had reportedly been “declared brain-dead” at a Bareilly hospital jolted back to life after the ambulance ferrying her home for the last rites ran into a pothole. The “miracle” brought much joy to the family, but also threw up disconcerting questions.

How was the woman declared dead? How did she “come back to life”? And how is “brain dead” defined?

Doctors are clear — this was no miracle, but a case of misdiagnosis. They caution that misinformation erodes trust in critical care.

“Brain death is irreversible... and if someone is waking up from ‘brain death’, they were never brain dead to begin with,” says Dr Prem Kumar, senior anaesthesiologist and intensivist,



ISTOCK

Kauvery Hospitals. Put simply, brain death is the irreversible loss of all brain functions, including the brainstem.

“The brainstem controls breathing, pupillary reflexes and other vital functions. Brain death usually occurs after catastrophic brain injury such as severe head trauma or a massive stroke. It is not reversible as the brain tissue is irre-

versibly damaged,” says Dr Rajeev Jayadevan, Convenor, Research Cell, Kerala State IMA.

OTHER CAUSES

Some conditions, though, mimic brain death. “Toxins or drugs with sedative effect entering the body in large doses, or metabolic problems like very low blood glucose can suppress brain function so pro-

foundly that the person becomes unconscious, stops responding and may even sometimes have dilated pupils and weak breathing. This can sometimes be mistaken for brain death, but is often fully reversible when the toxins disappear from the system or metabolic disturbances are resolved. In fact, certifying brain death first requires ruling out toxins and similar reversible causes,” Dr Jayadevan explains.

While it may not be possible to determine the exact sequence of events in the Bareilly case without the patient’s medical records, the presence of reversible factors would mean that it was not brain death to begin with, he says.

That distinction is crucial because diagnosing brain death is not a matter of clinical impression. It follows a rigorous protocol. Under India’s organ transplant rules, a panel of four doctors must conduct a series of tests, including assessment

of brainstem reflexes, pupillary reflexes, and apnoea test, and repeat them after a gap of six hours, while also ruling out confounding factors such as drugs, toxins or metabolic disturbances.

In contrast, the Glasgow Coma Scale (GCS), cited in such reports, as a yardstick to assess the depth of unconsciousness, is not sufficient to establish brain death. Patients with low GCS scores can and do recover if the underlying cause is treated, Kumar observes.

Doctors say the reported “miracles” are fertile grounds for myth generation, blur the poorly understood distinction between brain death and coma, and give misplaced hope to families.

Such misinformation also affects cadaver organ donation decisions, where brain death is the basis for consent, leading to loss of trust in the system, Dr Kumar rues.

QUICKLY.

Jaishankar to address
India-Russia trade meet



Moscow: External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and his Russian counterpart Sergei Lavrov will on Monday virtually address a conference that will see experts from the two sides deliberate on navigating the choppy waters amid tensions in the Gulf region. The one-day conference, organised by the Embassy of India in Moscow and the Russian International Affairs Council (RIAC), is especially significant considering the impact of the ongoing conflict in the Gulf region on the International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC). Iran's Bandar Anzali, which faced damage due to a missile strike by US-Israel on March 18, is a major port on the corridor that is a crucial link between Mumbai and St Petersburg, bypassing the Suez Canal, to boost trade between Asia and Europe. **PTI**

Govt considering additional measures to support airlines

TAILWINDS. After removing airfare cap, it mulls lowering airport fee for parked planes

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The Centre is mulling a reduction in statutory charges, including airport parking fees, to provide relief to airlines even as it has removed the temporary airfare caps to ease the financial stress in the sector.

Speaking to *businessline*, industry sources said: “After removing airfare caps, there is a discussion on lowering airport fees for parked aircraft that were earlier deployed to the Gulf region.”

Gulf routes, which account for a significant share of international flights for most Indian carriers, have been disrupted for close to a month. Industry stakeholders confirmed that the government is considering additional measures to support Indian carriers.

The Centre has removed temporary airfare caps, offering much-needed relief to cash-strapped airlines grap-



NO-FLY ZONE. Gulf routes, which account for a significant share of international flights for Indian carriers, have been disrupted for a month

pling with surging fuel costs and operational pressures.

The decision comes days after India-based carriers warned of potential flight cuts, fleet groundings and job losses, citing mounting financial strain driven by high aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices, a weak rupee and high airport charges.

GREATER FLEXIBILITY

Notably, industry sources said the removal of fare caps will allow airlines greater flexibility to price tickets in line with market conditions, enabling a partial pass-through of rising input costs.

Airlines had earlier flagged to the Ministry of Civil Aviation that regulatory constraints on fares were exacerbating losses at a time when operating expenses had surged sharply.

Besides, they sought relief from the high ATF prices, which remain a key concern. Jet fuel prices across metro cities rose by nearly six per cent in the latest revision earlier this month.

Consequently, airlines imposed fuel surcharges on both domestic and international routes from March 2026, citing rising ATF prices and high fuel taxes.

“The move to remove the fare cap provides critical headroom for airlines to manage yields better, especially during peak travel periods,” said a senior industry executive.

Furthermore, the decision assumes significance as carriers prepare for the peak summer travel season, even as geopolitical tensions in West Asia continue to keep global crude oil markets volatile.

Industry observers noted that any sharp increase in ticket prices could impact passenger demand, particularly on price-sensitive domestic routes.

“The recent government notification scrapping temporary airfare caps does not give airlines a free hand to charge arbitrarily. Airlines have already raised fuel surcharges, and such surcharges only cover shocks arising from the rise in fuel prices,” said Mark Martin, Founder and CEO of Martin Consulting.

Air India Express plans to drop Hindon airport from network

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai



EXPANSION PLANS. AAI has drawn up a plan that will result in the expansion of the terminal and increase in-flight handling capacity **REUTERS**

Air India Express is pulling out of Hindon airport, barely a year after launching operations to the National Capital Region airport.

At present, Air India Express operates flights from Hindon to Mumbai and Bengaluru.

While demand is not a constraint, operational challenges at Hindon, aircraft availability and the upcoming launch of the Noida airport are said to have guided Air India Express' plans.

The airline did not respond to an e-mail query. Air India Express' website shows that flights from Hindon to Bengaluru and Mumbai are available for sale only till March 27, the last day of the winter schedule.

IndiGo and Star Air will continue to operate from Hindon airport.

Data from aviation analytics firm Cirium show 35 per cent fewer flights have been scheduled from Hindon in April over a month-on-month basis, with IndiGo re-

ducing some of its services.

According to the Airport Authority of India, Hindon airport handled 9.6 lakh passengers between April and January.

The airfield has two parking bays and a small terminal, hindering its growth.

Occasionally, this also led to aircraft holding 20-25 minutes as the bays remain occupied.

EXPANSION PLANS

Hindon airport is owned by the Indian Air Force, and the AAI runs a civil terminal.

Passenger flights began from Hindon under the Ude

Desh ka Aam Nagrik (Udan) scheme in October 2019.

The AAI has drawn up a plan that will result in the expansion of the terminal and increase in-flight handling capacity at Hindon airport.

The authority asked Uttar Pradesh for around 9 acres of land, and the State is said to have agreed in principle to acquire 6.5 acres for the expansion.

As an interim measure, the existing terminal is being expanded by 700 sq m.

This will help reduce congestion and in the addition of passenger amenities, said an official.

Smartphone brand Nothing aims to add 5,000 offline touchpoints in India

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Long before opening hours, a queue had formed outside the London-based consumer tech company Nothing's first exclusive store in Bengaluru, an early signal of how Indians' smartphone-buying journey is shifting.

On a Saturday morning, customers lined up to get their hands on the newly launched Phone (4a) and Phone (4a) Pro. “The footfall

is insane... we had nearly 700-750 people in a day. It's been way above any of our expectations,” said Akis Evangelidis, Co-founder and India President.

The response has been so strong that the company thinks the store will turn profitable within its first year, well ahead of expectations.

The company plans to expand its experiential store format across key metros, including Mumbai, Delhi and Hyderabad, while continuing

to deepen its multi-brand retail presence.

The strategy is to build one flagship store per city, complemented by wider offline distribution.

The company plans to build on its retail touchpoints to 15,000 by the year-end, up from approximately 10,000 at present.

“Offline is picking up in India in quite a big way... it's now slightly tilted towards offline, around 55 per cent, versus 45 per cent online,” said Evangelidis.

Indriya eyes 100-plus stores as it aims to build national presence

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Indriya, the jewellery brand from the Aditya Birla Group, is racing towards a three-digit store count as it simultaneously moves to build national brand stature through high-visibility fashion platforms, a dual push that is reshaping its marketing playbook less than two years after launch.

The brand, which currently operates over 55 stores across 30-plus cities, is on track to cross 75 stores by the end of March. In a con-

versation with *businessline*, Shantiswarup Panda, Head of Marketing and Visual Merchandising at Indriya, said the company will soon cross into triple-digit store territory, without disclosing a specific timeline. “We will be crossing the two-digit mark to the three-digit mark very soon,” he said.

The rapid rollout reflects a strategic inflection point. Panda said the brand's challenge has flipped since launch. “Earlier, there was no awareness, we had limited presence. Now, the awareness is there, consideration is there but accessibility is



not there,” he said, adding that faster expansion will allow the same marketing spend to reach a broader consumer base.

PRIMARY TOOLS

To fund that consideration,

Indriya is moving beyond performance and hyperlocal digital advertising, its primary tools at launch, towards mass media, satellite television and high-visibility fashion platforms.

The brand made its debut at the Lakme Fashion Week this week with a showcase titled *Illuminate*, in collaboration with designer Amit Aggarwal, following an earlier appearance at the Paris Couture Week in January alongside Gaurav Gupta.

Panda positioned these not as vanity plays but as brand-stature investments. “Events like this help you

build the stature much faster,” he said, distinguishing their role from conventional advertising, which he said primarily drives reach and limited consideration. The Lakme showcase is accompanied by a four-day experience zone at the venue, where the brand is displaying jewellery and demonstrating its craft heritage alongside the runway event.

Panda said Indriya straddles price points, ranging from entry level fine jewellery to luxury, targeting women aged 20 to 60 years in urban NCCS AB1 households.

Yamaha Music names AR Rahman as brand ambassador

Our Bureau
Chennai

Yamaha Music India Private Ltd, the Indian subsidiary of Japan's Yamaha Corporation, has announced music icon AR Rahman as brand ambassador.

The announcement was made at a press event here on Sunday. At the event, Rahman highlighted Yamaha's role in his own musical journey, and said the company's products will be a part of his music school in Chennai.

“Yamaha has always represented precision and reliability. I am proud to associate with them, and this partnership is already benefiting young talents being nurtured at my own KM Mu-



CALLING THE TUNE. AR Rahman with Taketoshi Yamamoto, MD, Yamaha Music India Pvt Ltd **BUOY GHOSH**

sic Conservatory and in the Sunshine Orchestra. If we continue to mentor young artists and strengthen music education, Indian musicians can lead on the global stage,” he added.

Taketoshi Yamamoto,

MD, Yamaha Music India, said India is one of the most important markets for Yamaha globally, and the company has been seeing strong double-digit growth since it opened doors in India in 2008.

“We have steadily expanded our presence in the Indian market and are now ready to move into the next stage of our growth here. As part of our efforts to grow the brand and inspire the next generation of musical talent, we are announcing AR Rahman as brand ambassador,” he said.

GROWTH PROSPECTS

The company currently operates a manufacturing facility in Chennai, along with its corporate office in Gurugram and an experience centre in Bengaluru. Looking ahead, Yamaha Music India expects to sustain a growth trajectory of around 13 per cent CAGR through FY27 and FY28, said Ryoji Maruyama, Sales Unit Head.

Sports economy doubled in four years, crossed \$2 billion-mark in 2025 : WPP Media report

Cricket business alone grew 17.9 per cent to ₹16,704.2 crore last year

Meenakshi Verma
Ambwani
New Delhi

India's sports economy crossed the \$2 billion-mark for the first time in CY2025 to reach ₹18,864 crore (\$2.13 billion), garnering a 13.4 per cent growth over the previous year, according to a report by WPP Media.

Sports ad spends, which constitute the largest component of the industry, rose 19.8 per cent year-on-year to ₹9,571 crore, contributing a 51 per cent share. Sports sponsorship spends also grew 7 per cent to ₹7,943 crore, accounting for 42 per cent of the total industry.

Meanwhile, athlete-oriented endorsement deals were valued at ₹1,350 crore, up 10.3 per cent over 2024, according to the report, *Sporting Nation: Building a Legacy*.

“In just four years, India's sports economy



STRONG PITCH. IPL franchises crossed the ₹1,000 crore-mark in cumulative team sponsorship revenues **VIJAY SONEJI**

doubled from ₹9,530 crore in 2021 to ₹18,864 crore in 2025, growing at a CAGR of about 19 per cent. CY2025 marks a structural inflection point, and this is no longer an emerging market story — it is a consolidation and scale story. The growth seen in 2025 reflects structural advertiser confidence,” said Vinit Karnik, MD – Content, Sports and Entertainment, WPP Media, South Asia.

CRICKET BUSINESS

The cricket business alone grew 17.9 per cent to ₹16,704.2 crore in 2025,

contributing nearly 89 per cent to the total industry. Despite the impact of the ban on real money gaming (RMG), cricket media spends grew to ₹9,026 crore in 2025. Digital spend acceleration continued to outpace linear TV. Also, IPL franchises crossed the ₹1,000 crore-mark in cumulative team sponsorship revenues.

“Rather than triggering a slowdown, the void created by the exit of RMG players was progressively absorbed by traditional brands as established sectors widened their presence. This indic-

ates that the commercial foundation of cricket has broadened beyond dependence on any single advertiser cohort. In fact, demand for premium inventory remained intact,” Karnik stated.

SPORTS REVENUES

However, emerging sports revenues declined 12.2 per cent in 2025 to ₹2,159.9 crore, indicating that the non-cricket sports ecosystem is still evolving. This decline was attributed to postponement of the Indian Super League and lack of any major non-cricketing multi-nation tournaments.

Emerging sports' share to the total sports industry is pegged at 11 per cent. It did see good momentum in terms of event-based tournaments such as the Neeraj Chopra Classic and the Messi Tour of India. Also, new-age sports, such as pickleball, have emerged, said the report.

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